Catechism.

YEAR 1 · UNIT 4 · DAYS 64-93

Job: Suffering and Sovereignty

Job 1-42

Before the law, a righteous man suffers. God answers not with explanation but with himself.

UNIT ANCHOR VERSE

"For I know that my Redeemer lives, and at the last he will stand upon the earth."

JOB 19:25

Psalms of the suffering righteous (10, 13, 22, 73, 88, 17, and 26) beside Job.

UNIT 4

In this unit

WEEK 10

64	Job 1:1-2:13	*Reading*
65	Psalm 10	*Psalm*
66	Psalm 13	*Psalm*
67	Job 3:1-4:21	*Reading*
68	Job 5:1-7:21	*Reading*
69	Job 8:1-10:22	*Reading*
70	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 11

71	Job 11:1-13:28	*Reading*
72	Job 14:1-17:16	*Reading*
73	Psalm 22:1-21	*Psalm*
74	Psalm 22:22-31	*Psalm*
75	Job 18:1-20:29	*Reading*
76	Job 21:1-23:17	*Reading*
77	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 12

78	Job 24:1-26:14	*Reading*
79	Job 27:1-28:28	*Reading*
80	Job 29:1-31:40	*Reading*
81	Job 32:1-34:37	*Reading*
82	Job 35:1-37:24	*Reading*
83	Job 38:1-39:30	*Reading*
84	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 13

85	Job 40:1-42:17	*Reading*

86	Ephesians 1:11; Romans 11:33-36; Job 42:1-6	*Doctrine*
87	Romans 8:18-30; 1 Peter 4:12-19; 2 Corinthians 4:7-18	*Doctrine*
88	Psalm 73	*Psalm*
89	Psalm 88	*Psalm*
90	Psalm 17	*Psalm*
91	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 14

92	Psalm 26	*Psalm*
93	Review and Reflection	*Review*

DAY 64 · WEEK 10

Job 1:1-2:13

The prologue in heaven; Job's suffering begins

Year 1 · Unit 4 · Reading · 42 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Job 1:1-2:13. This is the prologue, and it is the only place in the book where you are allowed to see behind the curtain. Read it as a story told in two settings: the courts of heaven and the ash heap on earth. Notice that Job never gets to read these two chapters.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

You have finished the Law and are now entering the wisdom literature. Job is probably the oldest story in this stretch of the Bible. The details point to the age of the patriarchs: Job's wealth is counted in livestock, he offers sacrifices as the head of his own household, and there is no mention of Israel, the exodus, or the law of Moses. The land of Uz lies outside the covenant people. That matters. God is showing you a man who knows him and fears him before the nations are sorted into Israel and everyone else. The book asks the oldest question people ask: why do the righteous suffer? And it will not let you answer too quickly.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Job is introduced as "blameless and upright, one who feared God and turned away from evil" (1:1). The narrator tells you this before anything goes wrong.
2. Job is wealthy, with seven sons, three daughters, and enormous flocks. He also offers burnt offerings on behalf of his children, "for Job said, It may be that my children have sinned" (1:5).
3. The scene shifts to heaven, where the sons of God present themselves before the LORD, and Satan comes among them (1:6).
4. The LORD, not Satan, brings up Job: "Have you considered my servant Job?" (1:8).

5. Satan's accusation is that Job fears God only because God pays him for it, "Does Job fear God for no reason?" (1:9).

6. God sets a limit. Satan may touch what Job has but not Job himself (1:12). In chapter 2, he may touch Job's body but must spare his life (2:6).

7. Four messengers arrive one after another, and Job loses oxen, donkeys, sheep, camels, servants, and finally all ten of his children (1:13-19).

8. Job worships: "The LORD gave, and the LORD has taken away; blessed be the name of the LORD" (1:21). The narrator adds, "In all this Job did not sin or charge God with wrong" (1:22).

9. Job's wife says, "Curse God and die" (2:9). Three friends arrive and sit with him in silence for seven days (2:11-13).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The first thing the prologue does is settle a question that the rest of the book will keep raising. Job's suffering is not a punishment for sin. The narrator says so, and God says so twice (1:8; 2:3). If you forget this, you will read the next thirty-nine chapters the way Job's friends do, looking for what Job must have done wrong.

The second thing the prologue does is show you that suffering has a larger setting than the person suffering. Satan appears as an accuser. His charge is a charge against God as much as against Job: that God's servants love him only because he pays them well, and that if the payment stops, so will the worship. The question on trial is whether God is worth loving for himself. Job does not know he is on trial. He does not know any of this is happening. That is a hard truth and a necessary one: sometimes the most important thing going on in your suffering is something you cannot see.

Notice the limits. Satan is not an equal of God. He cannot act until he receives permission, and the permission has a boundary every time. This is not a comfortable picture, because it means God is sovereign even over the hand that strikes Job. But it is also the only picture in which suffering has a limit and an end. The book will not explain to Job why God permitted it. It will show that God remained in charge.

Then look at Job's response. He tears his robe and shaves his head, which are the actions of real grief, and then he falls to the ground and worships. He does not pretend that nothing happened. He does not say that it is fine. He says that the LORD gave and the LORD has taken away, and he blesses the name of the LORD anyway. Chapter 2 sharpens the test. His wife,

who has lost everything too, tells him to give up. Job answers, “Shall we receive good from God, and shall we not receive evil?” (2:10). That is not cold stoicism. It is a man who has decided that God is not only a giver of gifts.

The last scene is the quietest. The friends sit with him for seven days and say nothing. It is the best thing they will do in the whole book.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus’ own story echoes Job’s. He too was declared righteous by the Father (“This is my beloved Son, with whom I am well pleased”) and then led into suffering at the hand of the accuser (Matthew 3:17-4:11). Revelation 12:10 names Satan as “the accuser of our brothers.” James holds up Job as an example of steadfastness (James 5:11).

STEP 6

Application

First, if you are suffering now, hear that your suffering is not automatic proof of anything about you. Do not assume that God is angry, and do not assume that he is absent.

Second, remember that Satan has a leash. Nothing in your life, including the worst thing, falls outside the limits God sets.

Third, practice Job’s honesty. You can grieve openly and worship at the same time. Say the true thing about the pain and the true thing about God, and do not let either cancel the other.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God that nothing touches your life beyond the limit he sets.
- Ask him to keep you from believing he has turned against you when you suffer.
- Pray for someone who is grieving today.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 10

“The LORD gave, and the LORD has taken away; blessed be the name of the LORD.”

JOB 1:21

DAY 65 · WEEK 10

Psalm 10

Where are you, LORD?, the lament when God seems hidden

Year 1 · Unit 4 · Psalm · 18 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 10. After the prologue of Job, this is the psalm of someone who is living inside the silence. Read it slowly and listen for how the psalmist moves from accusation to confidence.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 10 was probably written by David, and in many ancient manuscripts it was joined with Psalm 9 as a single poem. Psalm 9 celebrates God's justice. Psalm 10 asks where that justice has gone. It is a lament about wicked people who seem to flourish while the poor are crushed. You have just watched Job lose everything while the wicked go on living. This psalm gives you words for what that feels like.

STEP 3

Observation

1. The psalm opens with two questions: "Why, O LORD, do you stand far away? Why do you hide yourself in times of trouble?" (v. 1).
2. The wicked man hunts the poor and boasts about his desires (vv. 2-3).
3. He does not seek God, and "all his thoughts are, There is no God" (v. 4).
4. He believes he will never be moved, and he treats God as if God has forgotten (vv. 5-6, 11).
5. His mouth is full of lies and oppression, and he lies in wait like a lion (vv. 7-10).
6. In verse 12 the psalmist cries, "Arise, O LORD; O God, lift up your hand; forget not the afflicted."

7. In verse 14 the psalmist says, “But you do see, for you note mischief and vexation.” The tone turns.

8. The psalm ends with confidence: “The LORD is king forever and ever” (v. 16), and he will “do justice to the fatherless and the oppressed” (v. 18).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The honesty of this psalm is part of its gift. It begins with a question that sounds close to an accusation: why do you hide? The Bible does not tell you to suppress that question. It hands you a prayer that asks it out loud. Prayer in the Psalms is not polite. It is true.

The middle of the psalm is a portrait of the wicked, and the details are chilling. The wicked man is proud, he is a predator, and he has talked himself into believing that nobody is watching. “God will never see it” (v. 11). Look at what drives his behavior. It is not that he has weighed the evidence and decided God does not exist. It is that he wants the freedom to do what he wants without anyone looking. Practical atheism works like that.

Then the turn at verse 12. The psalmist does not receive an answer to his question. What he does is change what he asks for. “Arise, O LORD” is a petition, and the petition quickly becomes a confession: “But you do see.” The same God who seemed to be hiding is now the God who notes every wrong. The psalmist has not changed his circumstances. He has recalled who God is.

The last verses are certain. “The LORD is king forever and ever.” The wicked have a short reign, and God has a permanent one. The psalm ends with the fatherless and the oppressed, because they are the ones God is listening to. “O LORD, you hear the desire of the afflicted” (v. 17).

This is how lament works. It states the problem honestly, it asks, and then it lets the character of God answer. Job will do exactly this over the next thirty-five chapters.

STEP 5

Connection

The psalm describes the kind of arrogance that Paul quotes in Romans 3:14 (“Their mouth is full of curses and bitterness”), taken from verse 7. Jesus said that God will “give justice to his elect, who cry to him day and night” (Luke 18:7). Revelation 6:10 hears the martyrs ask the same question, “How long, O Lord?”

STEP 6

Application

If God feels distant right now, pray this psalm back to him word for word. Do not clean up the question. Then, as the psalmist does, say out loud one thing you know to be true of God: that he sees, that he is king, that he hears the afflicted.

Also, take note of who in your life is being crushed by someone more powerful, and ask what a God who hears the afflicted would want you to do.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God plainly where he seems far away.
- Pray for someone who is afflicted and ask how you might help.
- Ask him to strengthen your heart to wait.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 10

"The LORD gave, and the LORD has taken away; blessed be the name of the LORD."

JOB 1:21

DAY 66 · WEEK 10

Psalm 13

How long, O LORD?, the short lament and its resolution

Year 1 · Unit 4 · Psalm · 6 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 13. It has only six verses. Read it three times, once for each of its three movements: the questions, the plea, and the song.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

This is one of the shortest laments in the Psalter and one of the most loved. David wrote it, but we do not know the occasion. Some think it came during the years he was hunted by Saul. Others think it was an illness. The lack of detail is deliberate. The psalm is meant to be prayed by anyone who has asked God, "How long?" It follows Psalm 10 and goes with Job: both are about holding on to God when God seems to be silent.

STEP 3

Observation

1. The first two verses ask "How long?" four times: forgotten forever, hiding his face, taking counsel in my soul, my enemy exalted (vv. 1-2).
2. The psalmist says that God has forgotten him, and the sorrow is "in my heart all the day" (v. 2).
3. In verse 3 the psalm turns to commands: "Consider and answer me, O LORD my God; light up my eyes."
4. He fears death: "lest I sleep the sleep of death" (v. 3).
5. He fears that his enemy will say "I have prevailed" (v. 4).
6. Verse 5 begins with a contrast: "But I have trusted in your steadfast love."
7. The psalm ends in song: "I will sing to the LORD, because he has dealt bountifully with me" (v. 6).

STEP 4

Interpretation

This psalm is built like a staircase. Each step is shorter than the last and leads upward. Verses 1 and 2 are four questions, and they are long and heavy. Verses 3 and 4 are three commands and a fear. Verses 5 and 6 are a statement of trust and a vow to sing. The rhythm of the poem acts out what happens in the heart of someone who prays honestly.

Pay attention to the phrase "How long?" It does not say "Why?" The question is not about the cause of the trouble. It is about duration. The psalmist can bear suffering for a season, but he cannot see an end to it, and that is what is crushing him. Many of us are in the same place. The pain is bearable only if it has a limit.

Then see what the psalmist asks for in verse 3. "Light up my eyes." He does not ask for a change in circumstances. He asks for sight. His eyes are going dim with grief, and he wants God to revive them. That is a prayer for perspective, and it is a good prayer.

The turn at verse 5 is the heart of the psalm. "But I have trusted." Nothing about the situation has changed between verse 4 and verse 5. The enemy is still there. God has not answered. What has changed is that the psalmist has chosen where to stand. He stands on God's "steadfast love," the covenant word, the word that means God will not walk away from his people. And from there he can do what seemed impossible in verse 1: rejoice and sing.

Notice that the song is a promise, not a report. "I will sing." He is singing before the rescue comes, and the reason he can is that he has already received something: God has dealt bountifully with him, and he is looking back on it.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus prayed a lament of his own on the cross, quoting Psalm 22:1. Paul said that "for those who love God all things work together for good" (Romans 8:28). Habakkuk 3:17-18 follows the same pattern: no fruit on the vines, yet "I will rejoice in the LORD."

STEP 6

Application

When you are asking "How long?", pray this psalm in the order it is written. State the pain honestly. Then ask God for light, not just for relief. Then say aloud, "But I have trusted in your steadfast love," and name one specific way you have seen that love in the past.

If you know someone who is waiting, send them verses 5 and 6 and tell them you are praying that they will sing again.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God “How long?” about the thing that weighs on you most.
- Remember aloud some ways he has been good to you.
- Tell him you trust him even here.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 10

“The LORD gave, and the LORD has taken away; blessed be the name of the LORD.”

JOB 1:21

DAY 67 · WEEK 10

Job 3:1-4:21

Job curses the day; Eliphaz responds, suffering as punishment

Year 1 · Unit 4 · Reading · 57 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Job 3:1-4:21. Chapter 3 is Job's lament, and chapter 4 is the first speech of his friend Eliphaz. Read them as a conversation between a man in pain and a man with a theory.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

After seven days of silence, Job finally speaks. What comes out is not a prayer to God and not a complaint about the friends. It is a wish to have never been born. The friends who sat silently beside him now begin to talk, and the rest of the book is a series of speeches. Most of Job is written in Hebrew poetry, and it is some of the most difficult poetry in the Bible. The speakers are not always right. The narrator does not tell you in each chapter who is right, so you must read with attention.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Job begins, "Let the day perish on which I was born" (3:3). He wishes the day had been darkness.
2. He asks why he was not stillborn, and why light is given to those in misery (3:11-20).
3. He says that death would have meant rest, where "the wicked cease from troubling, and the weary are at rest" (3:17).
4. Job says, "For the thing that I fear comes upon me, and what I dread befalls me" (3:25).
5. Eliphaz begins gently, asking if Job will be impatient (4:2).
6. He reminds Job that he has comforted others (4:3-4).
7. Eliphaz states his principle: "Who that was innocent ever perished? Or where were the upright cut off?" (4:7).

8. He describes a night vision of a spirit that said, “Can mortal man be in the right before God?” (4:12-17).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Start with Job’s lament. It would be easy to see it as a failure of faith. It is not. Notice who Job is not cursing. In verse 1 he curses the day of his birth, not God. He has not yet said anything against God. That restraint is easy to miss, and the narrator wants you to see that Job is still holding on even as he wishes he were dead.

The lament also shows how deep the grief is. Job does not want to die in order to be rid of God. He wants rest. “There the prisoners are at ease together” (3:18). He is exhausted. There is something very honest in this chapter, and the Bible makes room for it. You do not have to be strong in order to be faithful.

Then comes Eliphaz, and his first speech sounds reasonable. He is kind at first. He is trying to help. But he holds a theory, and the theory is stated in 4:7-8: the innocent do not perish, and “those who plow iniquity and sow trouble reap the same.” If Job is suffering, Job must have sinned. This is the principle of retribution, and it is true in a general way: sin has consequences, and wisdom tends to lead to life. Proverbs says so. But Eliphaz has taken a general truth and turned it into a rule that explains every single case. Job’s suffering does not fit the rule, and so Eliphaz must either change the rule or accuse Job.

The night vision is worth noticing too. Eliphaz claims a spiritual experience as proof. The message he reports, that no human is righteous before God, is true. Paul will say the same in Romans 3. But it is used wrongly here. It is a true statement that Eliphaz uses as a club.

Be careful to read this as a lesson on how to comfort. The friends could have kept silent. They could have wept. Instead they explained. Explaining pain to a person in pain, before you understand it, is not comfort.

STEP 5

Connection

Jonah also wished to die (Jonah 4:3), and so did Elijah (1 Kings 19:4), and God cared for both of them. Jesus rejected the same theory of retribution when his disciples asked whether a man’s blindness was caused by his sin or his parents’ (John 9:1-3). “Neither this man nor his parents sinned.”

STEP 6

Application

First, if you have said dark things to God in your pain, take comfort that Job did too, and that Scripture records it without rebuke.

Second, watch yourself when someone else is hurting. Before you offer a reason, offer your presence. Ask yourself whether you are trying to help them or to make yourself feel that the world is safe.

Third, test any belief that says "good people always get good things." It is not what the Bible says.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Bring God your darkest thoughts without hiding them.
- Ask him to keep you from explaining away another person's pain.
- Ask him to teach you to sit with those who weep.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 10

"The LORD gave, and the LORD has taken away; blessed be the name of the LORD."

JOB 1:21

DAY 68 · WEEK 10

Job 5:1-7:21

Eliphaz concludes; Job replies, the cry of the afflicted soul

Year 1 · Unit 4 · Reading · 74 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Job 5:1-7:21. Eliphaz finishes his speech in chapter 5, and Job answers in chapters 6 and 7. Notice the turn in chapter 7, when Job stops speaking to his friends and begins speaking to God.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Yesterday Eliphaz began his speech with a general rule. Today he finishes it. His tone moves from correction to advice, and he gives Job a plan: seek God, accept discipline, and everything will be restored. He means well. But a plan of recovery assumes that Job did something wrong. Job's reply is the first long speech where he speaks both to his friends and to God, and it is one of the rawest passages in Scripture.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Eliphaz says, "Man is born to trouble as the sparks fly upward" (5:7).
2. He advises, "As for me, I would seek God, and to God would I commit my cause" (5:8).
3. He describes God as one who "does great things and unsearchable, marvelous things without number" (5:9) and who lifts the lowly (5:11).
4. He says, "Behold, blessed is the one whom God reproves; therefore despise not the discipline of the Almighty" (5:17).
5. Job answers, "Oh that my vexation were weighed" (6:2), and says his words have been rash because of his pain.
6. Job compares his friends to a seasonal stream that dries up in the heat when travelers need it (6:15-21).

7. He asks, “Teach me, and I will be silent; make me understand how I have gone astray” (6:24).

8. In chapter 7 he says, “My days are swifter than a weaver’s shuttle” (7:6) and “I will not restrain my mouth” (7:11).

9. He asks God, “What is man, that you make so much of him…that you visit him every morning and test him every moment?” (7:17-18).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Eliphaz sounds wise because much of what he says is true. God does lift up the lowly. God does discipline those he loves. Later the writer of Hebrews will quote Proverbs about this very thing (Hebrews 12:5-6). The problem is that Eliphaz applies it to Job without knowing anything about Job’s case. The truth is real, and the application is wrong. That is one of the hardest things to learn about reading and using Scripture: a true statement can be false in a particular place.

Job’s reply begins with a plea for understanding. “Oh that my vexation were weighed.” He is not asking his friends to agree with him. He is asking them to see the weight of what he carries. And he makes an honest complaint about their help. They are like a wadi in the desert, running with water in the winter and gone in the heat. When a traveler most needs water, there is none. A friend’s faithfulness is measured in the dry season.

Then he makes a request that is entirely fair. “Teach me, and I will be silent.” He is open to correction. “How forceful are upright words! But what does reproof from you reprove?” (6:25). If they can show him a sin, he will listen. They cannot, because there is none to show.

Chapter 7 is where the speech changes direction. Job stops talking about his friends and begins talking to God. His language is bitter. He sees life as hard service and hired labor, he cannot sleep, and his skin is breaking. He asks God, “Am I the sea, or the sea monster, that you set a guard over me?” (7:12). He even parodies Psalm 8. Where David asked in wonder, “What is man that you are mindful of him?”, Job asks in pain what man is that God cannot leave him alone.

Do not read this as rebellion. Notice that Job is still speaking to God. The friends talk about God, and Job talks to him. That difference is the whole difference between theology as theory and faith as a relationship, and it is the reason God will say later that Job spoke rightly.

STEP 5

Connection

Hebrews 12:5-11 quotes Proverbs 3:11-12 on discipline, and it is meant for children who are being trained, not for people who are suffering unjustly. Psalm 8 is the passage Job twists in 7:17-18, and Hebrews 2:5-9 reads Psalm 8 as fulfilled in Jesus. Psalm 88 will show you another prayer that does not end with comfort.

STEP 6

Application

When you read the Bible to comfort or counsel someone, ask whether the verse fits their situation, or whether you are using it to solve your own discomfort with their pain.

When you are the one in pain, pray as Job did. Speak to God, not only about him. If your prayers sound bitter, take them to the one person who can bear them.

Think of a person who was a seasonal stream for you, and one who was a river. Aim to be the second.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Bring your complaints to God and not around him.
- Ask him to make you a faithful friend in someone's dry season.
- Ask for wisdom to speak truth with love.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 10

"The LORD gave, and the LORD has taken away; blessed be the name of the LORD."

JOB 1:21

DAY 69 · WEEK 10

Job 8:1-10:22

Bildad speaks; Job questions God's justice

Year 1 · Unit 4 · Reading · 79 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Job 8:1-10:22. Bildad speaks in chapter 8, and Job responds in chapters 9 and 10. Pay attention to the question Job asks in 9:2, because the whole book is about it.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Bildad is the second friend to speak. Eliphaz relied on a personal experience. Bildad relies on tradition: what "the fathers" have taught. His speech is harder than Eliphaz's. He even suggests that Job's children died because of their own sin. Job answers with something new. He does not argue that he is innocent, but he asks a deeper question: even if a man were innocent, how could he ever win a case against God? He wishes there were someone to stand between them.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Bildad asks, "Does God pervert justice? Or does the Almighty pervert the right?" (8:3).
2. He says, "If your children have sinned against him, he has delivered them into the hand of their transgression" (8:4).
3. He tells Job that if he is pure and upright, God will rouse himself and restore him (8:5-6).
4. He appeals to the wisdom of earlier generations (8:8-10).
5. Job answers, "But how can a man be in the right before God?" (9:2).
6. He says that God is so powerful that no one can contend with him: "If it is a contest of strength, behold him! If it is a matter of justice, who can summon him?" (9:19).
7. Job says, "There is no arbiter between us, who might lay his hand on us both" (9:33).

8. In chapter 10 he addresses God directly: “I loathe my life…I will say to God, Do not condemn me; let me know why you contend against me” (10:1-2).

9. He asks God, “Did you not pour me out like milk and curdle me like cheese?” and remembers that God made him (10:10).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Bildad’s mistake is cruel, though he does not mean it to be. He does what the friends all do: he turns suffering into a verdict. The death of Job’s children is, to Bildad, proof that they were guilty. It is hard to imagine a colder thing to say to a grieving father. But notice that Bildad believes he is defending God. His first question is a real one: “Does God pervert justice?” The answer is no, and Job would agree. The error is in thinking that he understands how God’s justice works in every case.

Job’s answer is much deeper. The question in 9:2 is the central one: “How can a man be in the right before God?” Job is not asking about his own sin. He is asking something bigger. God is so great and so strong that no human being could stand before him in court. Even if I were innocent, he says, my own mouth would condemn me. He sees clearly what Bildad does not: that the real problem between God and humanity is not a technical question about who deserves what. It is the distance between a holy God and a creature.

That leads Job to the most important wish in the chapter. “There is no arbiter between us.” He wishes for a mediator, someone with a hand on God and a hand on Job, who could bring them together. Job does not yet know that he is longing for a person God will one day send. He only knows that he needs one.

In chapter 10 his wild words turn into something like faith. He remembers that God made him, shaped him like clay, and knit him together with bones and sinews (10:8-12). The one who is attacking him is the one who made him. That memory does not remove the pain, but it makes the pain a question rather than a verdict: if you made me, why are you doing this?

This is one of the strange gifts of Job. He is allowed to ask the question without being told that the question is out of bounds.

STEP 5

Connection

Paul says that “there is one God, and there is one mediator between God and men, the man Christ Jesus” (1 Timothy 2:5). Hebrews 9:15 says Christ is “the mediator of a new covenant.” Job’s cry for an arbiter finds its answer in Jesus, who has laid a hand on God and on us. The picture of God as potter is also in Isaiah 64:8 and Romans 9:20-21.

STEP 6

Application

Do not think that you can win an argument with God. Ask instead for the Mediator. Spend time thanking Jesus for being the one who stands between you and the Father.

Also, notice how easy it is to comfort yourself by finding a reason that other people suffer, such as “they must have done something.” Resist that. Every time you catch yourself doing it, pray for the person instead.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God what makes you feel unable to stand before him.
- Thank Jesus for being the mediator Job longed for.
- Ask him to make you gentle with those who suffer.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 10

“The LORD gave, and the LORD has taken away; blessed be the name of the LORD.”

JOB 1:21

DAY 70 · WEEK 10

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 4 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Spend your time with the memory verse. Read Job 1:21 slowly, three times, and then close your Bible and say it from memory. Then read the meditation and the review of the week, and choose one of the three questions to write about or to talk over with someone you trust.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"The LORD gave, and the LORD has taken away; blessed be the name of the LORD."

JOB 1:21

REST

Meditation

Job 1:21 is the confession of a man who has just lost everything. It is short enough to carry in your head, and heavy enough that it will take a lifetime to learn.

"The LORD gave." Job begins with gratitude. He has not forgotten what he received. The children, the land, the livestock, and the health were all gifts, and he names them as gifts. Everything good in your life is a gift too, and gratitude is the first step in learning to worship.

"And the LORD has taken away." This is the hard part, and Job does not soften it. He does not say that Satan took away, or that raiders took away, though both are true in the story. He sees through the second causes to the sovereign God who permits them. He does not say that God is guilty. He says that God is God. This is one of the most mature statements in Scripture, and it is not easy to say.

“Blessed be the name of the LORD.” The verse does not stop with the loss. It ends with praise, and the praise is aimed at the same LORD who gave and took. Job is not praising loss. He is praising the one who is greater than loss.

For the Christian, this verse takes on a new shape in light of the cross. The Father gave his Son, and the Son was taken away, and yet in that giving and taking is the greatest blessing in history. Job could not see that yet. You can.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you began Unit 4 and the book of Job. You were taken behind the curtain into heaven, where Satan accused Job and God set a limit on what he could do. You watched Job lose his children and his wealth and his health, and you heard him worship. You read two laments, Psalm 10 and Psalm 13, which gave you words for the question “Where are you, LORD?” and the question “How long?” Then the friends arrived. You heard Eliphaz suggest that Job’s suffering must be the result of sin, and Bildad go further and say that Job’s children had earned their deaths. Job answered with grief, with bitterness, and with the first stirrings of a longing for a mediator. The week taught that suffering is not a verdict, and that faithful people are allowed to ask hard questions.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Job lost almost everything, and he worshiped. Is there something you have lost, or are afraid of losing, that you need to place again in God’s hands? Write down what it is, and then write “The LORD gave, and the LORD has taken away; blessed be the name of the LORD” beside it.

How does Job’s longing for an “arbiter” who could stand between him and God (9:33) point you to Christ? Think about what it means that Jesus has laid his hand on both God and humanity. What would Job say if he could see the cross?

Which of Job’s friends do you most resemble when someone you love is hurting? What would it look like this week to sit silently with someone instead of offering explanations?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for what he has given, and place in his hands what you fear to lose.

Thank Jesus, the mediator Job longed for.

Rest in his care as the week ends.

DAY 71 · WEEK 11

Job 11:1-13:28

Zophar's rebuke; Job answers, I have heard all this before

Year 1 · Unit 4 · Reading · 81 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Job 11:1-13:28. Zophar, the third friend, speaks in chapter 11. Job's reply fills chapters 12 to 14, but you will read the first part today, ending at chapter 13. As you read, mark every place where Job turns from his friends to speak to God.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Now all three friends have spoken once. Eliphaz argued from experience and Bildad argued from tradition. Zophar is the sharpest of the three, and he argues from sheer confidence. He tells Job that he knows what God is thinking. Job's answer begins with sarcasm and ends with one of the most daring statements of faith in the Bible. He will not give up on God, and he will not give up on the truth, and he is willing to say so to God's face.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Zophar asks, "Should a multitude of words go unanswered, and a man full of talk be judged right?" (11:2).
2. He wishes that God would speak and tell Job "that God exacts of you less than your guilt deserves" (11:6).
3. He asks, "Can you find out the deep things of God? Can you find out the limit of the Almighty?" (11:7).
4. He promises that if Job repents, "you will forget your misery" and "your life will be brighter than the noonday" (11:13-17).
5. Job answers with sarcasm: "No doubt you are the people, and wisdom will die with you" (12:2).

6. Job says, “I have understanding as well as you; I am not inferior to you” (12:3). He says he has become a laughingstock to his friends.
7. He describes God’s power over nations and rulers: “He makes nations great, and he destroys them” (12:23).
8. He calls the friends “worthless physicians” and “whitewashers” who lie on God’s behalf (13:4, 7).
9. Job says, “Though he slay me, I will hope in him; yet I will argue my ways to his face” (13:15).
10. He asks, “Why do you hide your face and count me as your enemy?” (13:24).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Zophar’s speech is a good example of a sound idea turned into a weapon. His question in 11:7 is a good one. No one can fully search out God. But he uses it against Job in the wrong way. He says that God’s wisdom is so deep that Job cannot possibly know that he is innocent. That is a remarkable thing to say to a man who has lost his children. If God is that deep, then Zophar should be more careful about telling Job what God is doing.

Job’s sarcasm in chapter 12 is earned. “Wisdom will die with you.” He tells them that he knows everything they have said. The wise sayings about God’s power and justice are not secret. Everyone knows them. The problem is not information. The problem is that they use these truths to hurt him. And then he does what none of them has done: he describes God’s power honestly. God overthrows the mighty and strips kings of their robes (12:17-21). God is a God who is not predictable, and the friends’ tidy picture of divine justice cannot contain him.

Then comes chapter 13, and the most famous line in this section. “Though he slay me, I will hope in him.” The ESV translation reflects one reading of the Hebrew. Some translations read it as “Behold, he will slay me; I have no hope.” Either way, the verse is full of tension, and the next clause is clear: “yet I will argue my ways to his face.” Job is not giving up on God. He is going to bring his case before God directly. He knows that the godless cannot approach God, and the fact that he is willing to do so is itself evidence of his faith (13:16).

Look at the difference between Job and the friends. The friends talk about God. Job wants to talk to God. They defend God, as though he needed it. Job asks for an audience. He is the one who takes God seriously, and so he is the one who is willing to be honest with him.

This is a kind of faith that asks questions and keeps coming back. It is not a faith that is afraid of the answer.

STEP 5

Connection

The picture of faith that hopes in God even when he seems to be an enemy shows up again in Abraham, who believed that God could raise Isaac from the dead (Hebrews 11:17-19), and in Jesus in Gethsemane: “Not my will, but yours, be done” (Luke 22:42). Habakkuk 3:17-19 is another echo.

STEP 6

Application

Think of one question you are afraid to ask God. Ask it this week, honestly and respectfully, in prayer. Then keep listening.

Be careful of the kind of confidence that Zophar has. If you ever find yourself certain about why someone else is suffering, that is a sign to stop talking.

Consider memorizing Job 13:15 as your own statement of faith.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God what you do not understand about what he is doing.
- Ask him to give you honesty in prayer and humility to wait.
- Ask him to keep you hoping in him.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 11

“Though he slay me, I will hope in him; yet I will argue my ways to his face.”

JOB 13:15

DAY 72 · WEEK 11

Job 14:1–17:16

"I know that my Redeemer lives"; the friends harden

Year 1 · Unit 4 · Reading · 90 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Job 14:1-17:16. Job reflects on the brevity of life, Eliphaz returns with a harsher speech, and Job answers by looking toward heaven for a witness. Read the speeches for the fragments of hope that keep breaking through.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The first round of speeches is over, and the second begins. The friends are getting harder, not softer. Eliphaz tells Job that his own mouth condemns him, and he spends a whole chapter describing the miserable life of the wicked, which is a pointed way of saying that Job is suffering because he is wicked. Job's replies show someone who is wearing out. He has no hope in his friends and almost none in this life. But in the middle of the despair, he reaches for something he can hardly name: a witness in heaven.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Job says, "Man who is born of a woman is few of days and full of trouble" (14:1).
2. He compares a person to a tree: "For there is hope for a tree, if it be cut down, that it will sprout again" (14:7), but man "lies down and rises not again" (14:12).
3. He asks, "If a man dies, shall he live again?" (14:14), and then expresses a hope that God would hide him in Sheol until his wrath has passed and then remember him.
4. Eliphaz accuses Job: "Your own mouth condemns you, and not I" (15:6).
5. Eliphaz describes the wicked man as one who "writhes in pain all his days" (15:20).
6. Job calls them "miserable comforters" (16:2) and says that God has worn him out (16:7).

7. Job says, “Even now, behold, my witness is in heaven, and he who testifies for me is on high” (16:19).
8. He pleads, “O earth, cover not my blood, and let my cry find no resting place” (16:18).
9. In chapter 17 he asks God to “lay down a pledge for me with yourself; who is there who will put up security for me?” (17:3).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The first thing to notice is that Job’s questions are about more than his own pain. In chapter 14 he thinks about human life in general. We are short-lived, like a flower, and we are fragile. A tree that is cut down can sprout again from the stump. A person who dies seems to have no such hope. This is the darkest thought in the chapter, and it presses on Job until he asks the question that the rest of the Old Testament will slowly answer: “If a man dies, shall he live again?”

Then Job does something remarkable. He imagines that the answer could be yes. “All the days of my service I would wait, till my renewal should come” (14:14). He pictures God hiding him in Sheol like a man put away until a storm passes, and then calling to him. “You would call, and I would answer you; you would long for the work of your hands” (14:15). Job is not stating a doctrine of resurrection. He is imagining a possibility, and he is aware that it is a longing and not a certainty. But the longing is there, and it will grow.

Eliphaz’s second speech has no such moment. He is stuck in his system and he hardens. He says Job’s own mouth proves his guilt. He gives a long picture of the fate of the wicked. Notice that Eliphaz is not entirely wrong about the general truth. But it has become a trap for him and for Job.

Job’s answer in chapter 16 contains a shift. He first says that God is against him, which is where the pain is sharpest. But then, in 16:19, he turns to heaven. “My witness is in heaven.” He does not know who this witness is. It is another longing, like the arbiter of 9:33. Job has been wishing for someone who can speak for him before God. Now he is saying that such a person exists. God himself, in some mysterious way, will be Job’s advocate against God. It is a paradox and he does not resolve it.

Chapter 17 picks up the same thought. Job asks God to put up security for him, because no one else will. Only God can stand surety for Job against God.

STEP 5

Connection

Paul will say that Christ's resurrection answers Job's question: "But in fact Christ has been raised from the dead, the firstfruits of those who have fallen asleep" (1 Corinthians 15:20). 1 John 2:1 says, "We have an advocate with the Father, Jesus Christ the righteous." Hebrews 7:22 says that Jesus became "the guarantor of a better covenant," the surety Job longed for.

STEP 6

Application

Spend time today thinking about the shortness of life. It can be a gift when it moves you to trust God, and it can be a burden when you use it as a reason to despair. Ask which one it is for you.

Remember that Jesus is the witness in heaven, the advocate, and the one who stood surety for you. Thank him specifically, and name something you needed an advocate for.

If you are tired of "miserable comforters," ask God to send you a faithful friend, and ask him to make you one.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God how worn out you are, if you are.
- Thank Jesus that because he lives, you will live.
- Ask him to send you comfort, and to make you a comfort to someone else.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 11

"Though he slay me, I will hope in him; yet I will argue my ways to his face."

JOB 13:15

DAY 73 · WEEK 11

Psalm 22:1-21

My God, my God, why have you forsaken me

Year 1 · Unit 4 · Psalm · 21 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 22:1-21. This psalm will be read twice in the next two days. Today, read the first half as the voice of someone in agony, and as you read, remember that Jesus quoted its first line from the cross.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 22 is attributed to David. We do not know the circumstances in which he wrote it, but the details of his suffering go far beyond anything we know of David's life. Hands and feet pierced, bones out of joint, clothes divided by lot. The New Testament sees these words as fulfilled in Jesus. The psalm is both a real prayer of a real man and a prophecy, and that is what makes it unique. It stands next to Job as one of the great statements of the suffering of a righteous person who feels forsaken.

STEP 3

Observation

1. The psalm begins, "My God, my God, why have you forsaken me? Why are you so far from saving me, from the words of my groaning?" (v. 1).
2. He says he cries by day and by night, but there is no answer (v. 2).
3. Verses 3-5 turn to God's holiness and the fact that the fathers trusted in him and were delivered.
4. In verse 6 he says, "But I am a worm and not a man, scorned by mankind and despised by the people."
5. The crowd mocks him: "He trusts in the LORD; let him deliver him" (v. 8).
6. He remembers that God has been with him since birth (vv. 9-10).

7. Enemies surround him like bulls and lions (vv. 12-13, 16).
8. His body is poured out like water, his heart is like wax, and "my tongue sticks to my jaws" (vv. 14-15).
9. "They have pierced my hands and feet…they divide my garments among them, and for my clothing they cast lots" (vv. 16-18).
10. He pleads, "But you, O LORD, do not be far off!" (v. 19) and "Save me from the mouth of the lion" (v. 21).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The most striking thing about the first line is the double name: "My God, my God." The psalmist feels forsaken, and in that moment he does not call God by a lesser name. He calls him "my God," twice. The sense of abandonment and the ownership of God sit side by side. This is the same paradox you saw in Job. The one who feels the most forsaken is the one who still says "my."

Verses 3 to 5 show how the psalmist uses memory as a weapon. He says, "Yet you are holy." He remembers that the fathers trusted God and were not put to shame. Memory is the way a person stays alive spiritually in a long night. When feeling fails, history holds.

Then the psalmist describes what it is like to be the object of contempt. "I am a worm and not a man." The crowd's mockery is the same sort of thing Job's friends do, only more brutal: "He trusts in the LORD; let him deliver him." The scorn of the crowd takes the very faith of the sufferer and turns it into a joke. That is a particular kind of pain, and the psalm gives it a name.

The physical description in verses 14 to 18 is overwhelming. And the language is so specific that the early church saw it as a portrait of the crucifixion. Crucifixion was not invented until centuries after David. Yet here are pierced hands and feet, bones out of joint, and a gambling match over clothing. The Gospels do not hide the fact that they are quoting this psalm. John 19:23-24 cites verse 18 directly.

The first half of the psalm ends in the cry of verses 19 to 21. It is still a cry. The rescue has not come yet. But the shift is already beginning, because the psalmist is asking God for help in the second person: "But you, O LORD." The turn happens in the next verse, and you will read it tomorrow.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus cried Psalm 22:1 from the cross (Matthew 27:46). The mockery in verse 8 is repeated by the chief priests (Matthew 27:43). The division of garments in verse 18 is quoted in John 19:24. Hebrews 5:7 says that Jesus "offered up prayers and supplications, with loud cries and tears, to the one who was able to save him from death."

STEP 6

Application

The next time you feel forsaken, use these words. Jesus prayed them before you, and so you are never praying alone. He knows the feeling from the inside.

Take time today to thank him for bearing the real abandonment, so that you might never be forsaken by the Father. Be specific. What did he take on himself?

If you are watching someone else suffer, do not mock their faith, even gently. Ask yourself whether a quick word of religious cheer is really a kind of mockery.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank Jesus for being forsaken so that you would not be.
- Tell God where you feel far from him.
- Thank him that he is near now.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 11

"Though he slay me, I will hope in him; yet I will argue my ways to his face."

JOB 13:15

DAY 74 · WEEK 11

Psalm 22:22-31

I will tell of your name, lament turns to praise

Year 1 · Unit 4 · Psalm · 10 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 22:22-31. Yesterday ended with a cry. Today the cry turns into praise. Read these verses aloud and notice who is included in the praise at the end.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

There is a break in Psalm 22 at verse 21. In Hebrew, the last words of that verse are something like “You have answered me.” The psalmist has been rescued. Everything after that point is a different kind of song. The man who was forsaken now tells others what God has done, and the song grows wider and wider until it takes in the whole earth and generations that have not yet been born.

STEP 3

Observation

1. The psalmist says, “I will tell of your name to my brothers; in the midst of the congregation I will praise you” (v. 22).
2. He calls the congregation to praise: “You who fear the LORD, praise him!” (v. 23).
3. The reason: “For he has not despised or abhorred the affliction of the afflicted, and he has not hidden his face from him, but has heard, when he cried to him” (v. 24).
4. He vows to fulfill his vows in the presence of those who fear God (v. 25).
5. “The afflicted shall eat and be satisfied; those who seek him shall praise the LORD” (v. 26).
6. “All the ends of the earth shall remember and turn to the LORD, and all the families of the nations shall worship before you” (v. 27).
7. “Kingship belongs to the LORD, and he rules over the nations” (v. 28).

8. Even the dead are included: “All the prosperous of the earth eat and worship; before him shall bow all who go down to the dust” (v. 29).

9. The psalm ends with a future generation hearing about it: “that he has done it” (v. 31).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Look at what the sufferer does the moment he is rescued. He does not keep it private. “I will tell of your name to my brothers.” The rescue is a story, and a story is for telling. This is the way the Bible thinks of salvation: it is not only something that happens to a person. It becomes something the community knows and celebrates.

Verse 24 is worth stopping at. It is the answer to the first line of the psalm. Back in verse 1, God seemed to have forsaken the psalmist and hidden his face. Now he says, “He has not hidden his face from him.” What looked like abandonment turned out not to be. In the middle of the darkness, God was hearing. That does not mean that the suffering was unreal. But it means that the suffering was never the last word about God’s attitude.

The scope of the praise is dizzying. From one man in agony, we move to the congregation, then to the afflicted who eat and are satisfied, then to all the ends of the earth, then to all the families of the nations, and then to the dead and the unborn. One sufferer’s deliverance becomes the occasion for the worship of the whole world. This is the shape of the gospel. Through one man’s suffering and vindication, the nations are gathered.

That is why the New Testament reads Psalm 22 as the story of Jesus. Hebrews 2:12 puts verse 22 in Jesus’ mouth: “I will tell of your name to my brothers; in the midst of the congregation I will sing your praise.” The risen Jesus calls his people brothers, and he sings with them. The psalm that begins in the loneliest hour of history ends with a Savior who is surrounded by a people he has redeemed.

The last verse is also worth keeping. “They shall come and proclaim his righteousness to a people yet unborn, that he has done it.” Those words reach all the way to you.

STEP 5

Connection

Hebrews 2:10-12 applies verse 22 to Jesus and his brothers. Revelation 7:9 pictures the fulfillment of verse 27: “a great multitude that no one could number, from every nation, from all tribes and peoples and languages.” Jesus’ last words from the cross in John 19:30, “It is finished,” may echo the final words of Psalm 22:31, “that he has done it.”

STEP 6

Application

Tell someone this week what God has done for you. It does not need to be dramatic. Practice saying, “Let me tell you what the LORD did.”

Also think about the nations. Is there a mission or missionary you could pray for or give to in light of verse 27? Choose one.

If you are in a hard season, return to verse 24 and ask God to help you believe it before you see it.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God that he has not hidden his face from you.
- Ask him for words to tell what he has done.
- Pray that he would gather people from every nation.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 11

“Though he slay me, I will hope in him; yet I will argue my ways to his face.”

JOB 13:15

DAY 75 · WEEK 11

Job 18:1-20:29

Bildad and Zophar intensify; Job's redeemer confession

Year 1 · Unit 4 · Reading · 79 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Job 18:1-20:29. Bildad and Zophar both make speeches, and between them Job gives a speech in chapter 19 that contains the most famous words in the book. Read chapter 19 slowly, and read verses 23 to 27 aloud.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

This is the second cycle of speeches, and the friends are escalating. Bildad's second speech is a chilling portrait of the fate of the wicked. Zophar's is much the same. The emotional force behind their words is fear: if Job is innocent, then their whole picture of the world is broken. So they must make him guilty. In the middle comes Job's answer, in which he is crushed, isolated, and accused, and out of the dark he says the thing for which the book is best known.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Bildad says, "Is the earth to be forsaken for you, or the rock to be removed from its place?" (18:4).
2. He describes the wicked as trapped, terrified, and forgotten, and says, "He has no offspring or descendant among his people" (18:19).
3. Job answers, "How long will you torment me and break me in pieces with words?" (19:2).
4. He says that God has wronged him and walled up his way (19:6-8).
5. Job's family and friends have abandoned him, and even young children despise him (19:13-19).

6. “Have mercy on me, have mercy on me, O you my friends, for the hand of God has struck me!” (19:21).
7. “Oh that my words were written! Oh that they were inscribed in a book! Oh that with an iron pen and lead they were engraved in the rock forever!” (19:23-24).
8. “For I know that my Redeemer lives, and at the last he will stand upon the earth” (19:25).
9. “And after my skin has been thus destroyed, yet in my flesh I shall see God, whom I shall see for myself, and my eyes shall behold, and not another” (19:26-27).
10. Zophar answers that the joy of the wicked is short (20:5), and that what they gain will be vomited up (20:15).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Bildad and Zophar use pictures that are meant to frighten. Their descriptions of the wicked person’s end are among the most vivid in the Bible. There is a light that goes out, a net that closes, terrors that chase him. But they are describing Job without saying his name. This is a kind of cruelty that wears the clothes of wisdom.

The speech Job gives in response is full of heartbreak. He lists everything he has lost in relationships: his brothers have estranged themselves, his close friends have forgotten him, his servants do not answer him, and his wife finds his breath strange. Even young boys despise him. To lose possessions is hard. To lose belonging is harder. Job begs his friends, “Have mercy on me.”

And then, out of this, comes the most astonishing section in the book. Job wishes that his words could be written down forever. He wants a permanent record, because he knows that his death will come before he has been vindicated. The words that follow are not a wish, though. They are a statement of certainty: “I know that my Redeemer lives.”

The Hebrew word for Redeemer is go’el, a legal term for the family member who rescues a relative in need: who buys back land lost to debt, who avenges a death, who protects the vulnerable. Job’s longing in chapter 9 for an arbiter and in chapter 16 for a witness has now become a conviction. He does not just hope for someone. He knows there is someone, and he calls that person a living Redeemer who “will stand upon the earth,” as though taking his place in a courtroom at the last.

And then the most daring part. “Yet in my flesh I shall see God.” Job expects to see God with his own eyes, after death, in his body. Whether he fully understood what he was saying is debated. But the words, set in the canon, carry a hope of bodily resurrection that is not fully

revealed until the New Testament.

Notice that the verse is spoken from the lowest point of the book. Hope is not the fruit of good circumstances. It is a decision made in the dark.

STEP 5

Connection

Boaz acts as a go'el in the book of Ruth, which you will read in Unit 8. Isaiah calls God Israel's Redeemer many times (Isaiah 41:14; 43:14; 54:5). Paul says in 1 Corinthians 15:51-57 that the dead will be raised imperishable. Jesus says, "I am the resurrection and the life" (John 11:25). Job's hope is realized in the risen Christ.

STEP 6

Application

Memorize Job 19:25 this week. It is the unit's theme verse. Say it aloud in the morning and at night.

Think about the Redeemer you have. What did Jesus do to buy you back, and what did it cost? Write a short paragraph about it.

If you have lost something in a relationship, say so honestly to God. Then ask him to hold the loss in his hand.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God what you believe about your Redeemer, in your own words.
- Ask him to anchor you in that hope when loss surrounds you.
- Thank Jesus for standing for you.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 11

"Though he slay me, I will hope in him; yet I will argue my ways to his face."

JOB 13:15

DAY 76 · WEEK 11

Job 21:1-23:17

Job confronts the prosperity gospel; God seems far

Year 1 · Unit 4 · Reading · 73 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Job 21:1-23:17. Job answers Zophar and challenges the friends' theory about the wicked. Eliphaz replies in chapter 22 with a direct accusation, and Job answers in chapter 23 with a longing to find God. Read chapter 23 as a prayer.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The friends have claimed that the wicked always suffer and the righteous always prosper. Job's answer in chapter 21 is simple and devastating: look around. In this world, wicked people often grow old, wealthy, and secure, and nothing happens to them. The friends' theory does not match what we see. This is the point where Job's book speaks most plainly against any teaching that promises health and wealth to those who follow God faithfully. Then comes a longing, one of the most moving in the book: Job wants to find God.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Job says, "Why do the wicked live, reach old age, and grow mighty in power?" (21:7).
2. He describes their children as secure, their herds as fertile, and their houses as safe (21:8-13).
3. The wicked say to God, "Depart from us!" and ask, "What is the Almighty, that we should serve him?" (21:14-15).
4. He says that both rich and poor die and lie down in the dust together (21:23-26).
5. Eliphaz now accuses him of specific sins: "Is not your evil abundant? There is no end to your iniquities" (22:5). He claims Job has not given water to the weary or bread to the hungry (22:7).

6. Eliphaz urges, “Agree with God, and be at peace; thereby good will come to you” (22:21).
7. Job says, “Oh, that I knew where I might find him, that I might come even to his seat!” (23:3).
8. “Behold, I go forward, but he is not there, and backward, but I do not perceive him” (23:8).
9. “But he knows the way that I take; when he has tried me, I shall come out as gold” (23:10).
10. “I have not departed from the commandment of his lips; I have treasured the words of his mouth more than my portion of food” (23:12).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Chapter 21 is the strongest rebuttal of the idea that faithful living guarantees comfort. Job takes the friends’ favorite claim and demolishes it with evidence. If the wicked always fall, why do so many seem to thrive? His statement is not an invitation to envy. It is an observation about the world as it is, and it agrees with what Psalms 37 and 73 say. Both say that the wicked prosper for a time, and that God’s justice has a different clock.

That matters for how you read the Bible. Proverbs makes general statements about wisdom leading to life. Job reminds you that those are not guarantees. A teaching that says “follow God and you will be healthy and rich” will break the first time it meets a Job. The Bible does not teach that.

Eliphaz’s response is the low point for the friends. He cannot answer Job’s evidence, so he invents charges. Job has never been accused of mistreating the poor, and the narrator has said that he is blameless. But in order to keep his theory, Eliphaz needs Job to be guilty, and so he makes up sins. This is what happens when a doctrine matters more than a person. It starts to lie.

Then Job goes quiet in a new way. In chapter 23 he stops arguing with the friends. He just wants God. “Oh, that I knew where I might find him.” His problem is not exactly that God is angry. It is that God is missing. He looks forward, backward, to the left and right, and he cannot see him. This is the experience of many believers in dark seasons, and it is described here without a trace of blame.

Yet there is trust in the middle of the darkness. “He knows the way that I take.” Job cannot see God, but God can see him. And “when he has tried me, I shall come out as gold.” It is not a claim that he deserves it. It is a confidence that God’s testing has a purpose and an end. Alongside that is his devotion to God’s word: he has treasured it more than his food.

STEP 5

Connection

Psalm 73, which you will read soon, struggles with the same puzzle of the prosperity of the wicked. Jesus said that God "makes his sun rise on the evil and on the good, and sends rain on the just and on the unjust" (Matthew 5:45). 1 Peter 1:6-7 speaks of faith "tested by fire" being "found to result in praise and glory and honor." James 5:11 holds up Job's endurance.

STEP 6

Application

Test any teaching you hear against the book of Job. If it promises that obedience will always bring health and wealth, it is not the teaching of the Bible.

When you cannot find God, pray Job 23:10 and ask him to hold you until you can see him again.

If you are in a season of dryness, treasure his words more than your food. Put your Bible reading first this week, before breakfast.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God honestly where you cannot find him.
- Ask him to refine you through what you are going through.
- Ask him to help you treasure his word above comfort.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 11

"Though he slay me, I will hope in him; yet I will argue my ways to his face."

JOB 13:15

DAY 77 · WEEK 11

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 4 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Job 13:15 aloud, slowly, several times, and then try to say it from memory. Read the meditation and the review of the week, and then pick one of the three questions for writing, prayer, or conversation.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"Though he slay me, I will hope in him; yet I will argue my ways to his face."

JOB 13:15

REST

Meditation

Job 13:15 is the sentence of a man who refuses two temptations at once.

The first temptation is to give up on God. Job has every reason to say that God is not good, that faith is a mistake, and that his friends were right about God being a tyrant. Instead he says, "I will hope in him." The verb is the verb of waiting, of leaning, of staking everything on someone. And the "though" in front of it makes the hope costly. It does not wait for the circumstances to improve. It hopes while the worst is happening.

The second temptation is the opposite one: to pretend. The friends have told Job to be quiet and humble and accept his guilt. He refuses that too. "Yet I will argue my ways to his face." He will not fake agreement. He is going to bring his case before God, in full honesty. His faith is not the silence of someone who has stopped asking. It is the courage of someone who believes that God can be asked.

Together, the two halves give you a picture of mature faith. It is not a calm faith that has no questions. It is a faith that has questions and takes them to God. Many of the saints have prayed this way. Learn it by heart, because you may need it in a hard season.

For the Christian, there is a final note. Jesus said something very close to this in the garden. He asked that the cup be taken from him, and he also said that the Father's will be done. He hoped in the Father even though the Father would slay him, and the Father raised him up.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you read the middle of the book of Job. You heard Zophar tell Job that he cannot know the mind of God, and Job answer that he has no intention of giving up on God or on the truth. You read Job's meditation on the shortness of life and his dim hope that a man who dies might live again. You read Psalm 22, the great cry of the forsaken and the song of the rescued, and you saw how Jesus prayed it from the cross. Then Bildad and Zophar piled on, and in the middle of the pain Job said, "I know that my Redeemer lives." By the end of the week, Job was confronting the idea that the righteous always prosper, and longing to find God. The week taught that real faith asks, waits, and still holds on.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Which is harder for you right now: to keep hoping in God when things go badly, or to bring him your honest questions? Write about what has made it difficult, and what one small step you could take.

How does Psalm 22, and the way Jesus prayed it, change the way you hear Job's cry? What does it mean that the Redeemer Job longed for has been through the loneliest night himself?

Think of a person in your life who needs a faithful friend, someone who will not give easy answers. What could you do for them this week?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Tell God where you want to hope in him even though you do not understand.

Thank him for the Redeemer who walked the darkest night before you.

Rest in his care this Sabbath.

DAY 78 · WEEK 12

Job 24:1-26:14

Why are times not kept by the Almighty? Bildad's last word

Year 1 · Unit 4 · Reading · 51 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Job 24:1-26:14. Job begins by asking why God does not set times for judgment, Bildad gives his last, very short speech, and Job answers with a hymn to God's power. Read chapter 26 as a poem about how little we know.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

This is the third and final cycle of speeches, and you can feel the friends running out of things to say. Eliphaz has spoken already. Bildad has only six verses left in him, and Zophar will not speak at all. Job's side of the argument keeps growing. In these chapters he first lists injustices that God seems to ignore, and then he turns and praises God's greatness with a sweep and beauty that exceeds anything the friends have said. The man who is accused of doubting God is the one who describes him best.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Job asks, "Why are times not kept by the Almighty, and why do those who know him never see his days?" (24:1).
2. He lists the oppressed: the poor driven from the road, orphans taken as a pledge, and laborers who go hungry while they carry the sheaves (24:2-12).
3. He says, "From out of the city the dying groan, and the soul of the wounded cries for help; yet God charges no one with wrong" (24:12).
4. Bildad asks, "How then can man be in the right before God? How can he who is born of woman be pure?" (25:4).
5. He calls man "a maggot" and "a worm" (25:6).

6. Job answers sarcastically: “How you have helped him who has no power!” (26:2).
7. He says, “Sheol is naked before God, and Abaddon has no covering” (26:6).
8. God “stretches out the north over the void and hangs the earth on nothing” (26:7).
9. “Behold, these are but the outskirts of his ways, and how small a whisper do we hear of him! But the thunder of his power who can understand?” (26:14).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Chapter 24 is a hard chapter to read because it is so honest about injustice. Job does not look away. He describes the poor picking through the leftovers of the rich, children taken as collateral, and the dying crying out in the city. And he says, “God charges no one with wrong.” This is a startling thing for a man of faith to say, but it is true to the way the world looks. Injustice happens, and it seems to go unnoticed. Job is saying what the psalmists say.

It is worth asking what he is asking for. He does not say that God does not exist, and he does not say that God is cruel. He says that the times are not “kept,” that the schedule of judgment is hidden from those who know God. That is a question about timing. And it points forward to a day of judgment, which Job will keep longing for.

Bildad’s speech is a sign that the friends are exhausted. His point in chapter 25 is that no human being is pure before God. That is true, and the New Testament will say it too. But look at what he does with it. He uses it to put Job down, in the cruel language of “maggot” and “worm.” Human weakness is a truth that is supposed to humble us before God. It is not supposed to be used as an insult.

And then Job speaks, and you can hear how much better a theologian he is. He answers Bildad’s short speech with a long, majestic description of God’s power: Sheol is open before him, the earth hangs on nothing, the clouds hold water without bursting, and the pillars of heaven tremble at his rebuke. He ends with a humble line that the friends could never say: “These are but the outskirts of his ways.” Even all of this is only the edge of what God is. We hear a whisper. The thunder is beyond us.

This is the proper stance of a creature. Job is not claiming to understand. He is claiming to trust a God who is bigger than his questions.

STEP 5

Connection

Psalm 94 asks God, “O LORD, how long shall the wicked exult?” Habakkuk 1:2-4 asks the same question about injustice. Paul says in Romans 11:33 that God’s ways are “unsearchable,” and in 1 Corinthians 13:12 that “now we see in a mirror dimly, but then face to face.” Revelation

6:10 and 19:2 show God answering the cry for justice.

STEP 6

Application

Make a list of injustices that weigh on you, in your own life, your community, or the world. Do not rush to resolve them. Take them to God as Job does.

Notice whether you tend to use humility as an insult, either toward yourself or toward others.

Then end by praising God for something in creation you cannot explain: the stars, the ocean, or the birth of a child. Remember that these are only the outskirts of his ways.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Bring an injustice you see to God.
- Thank him that he will one day judge the world in righteousness.
- Ask him to make you someone who acts with justice and mercy.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 12

"Behold, the fear of the Lord, that is wisdom, and to turn away from evil is understanding."

JOB 28:28

DAY 79 · WEEK 12

Job 27:1-28:28

Job's integrity; the hymn to wisdom, where shall it be found?

Year 1 · Unit 4 · Reading · 59 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Job 27:1-28:28. Job holds to his integrity in chapter 27, and in chapter 28 there is a famous poem about wisdom. Notice how the poem is built: first a long description of what human beings can find, then a question about what they cannot.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Zophar has not replied, and the three friends fall silent. Job speaks on, and in the next three chapters he gives his final defense. Chapter 27 is a vow to keep his integrity. Chapter 28 is different in tone and in kind. It is a hymn on wisdom that sounds almost like Proverbs, and some scholars think it is the narrator's own voice. Whatever its source, it is placed at the center of the book, and it gives the book's central answer to the question of how a person can find wisdom in a world of suffering.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Job swears an oath: "As God lives, who has taken away my right, and the Almighty, who has made my soul bitter" (27:2).
2. He says that as long as he has breath, "my lips will not speak falsehood" (27:3-4).
3. "Far be it from me to say that you are right; till I die I will not put away my integrity from me" (27:5).
4. "I hold fast my righteousness and will not let it go; my heart does not reproach me for any of my days" (27:6).
5. Chapter 28 begins with mining: "Surely there is a mine for silver, and a place where gold is refined" (28:1).

6. Humans dig “a shaft in a valley away from where anyone lives” and “overturn mountains by the roots” (28:4, 9).
7. “But where shall wisdom be found? And where is the place of understanding?” (28:12).
8. It cannot be bought for gold or silver or onyx or sapphire (28:15-19).
9. “God understands the way to it, and he knows its place” (28:23).
10. “Behold, the fear of the Lord, that is wisdom, and to turn away from evil is understanding” (28:28).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Chapter 27 is Job’s refusal to be pushed into a false confession. The friends have told him many times to repent, and he cannot, because he knows that he has not done what they say. He is not claiming to be sinless. He is saying that he did not bring this suffering on himself. To say otherwise would be to lie, and he will not lie even to please God, because he believes that God does not want his lies. This is a quiet kind of courage.

Then chapter 28 shifts the whole mood. The poem begins by describing the astonishing ability of human beings. We dig deep into the earth, we find silver and gold and sapphires, we reach places where birds and lions have never been. There is nothing human beings cannot find with enough labor. This is the picture of a technological, adventurous people.

And then the poem asks the question that all of that effort cannot answer: “But where shall wisdom be found?” It is hidden even from the eagle and the vulture. You cannot buy it. You cannot mine it. Death and the Abyss say, “We have heard a rumor of it.” The whole point of the poem is that wisdom is not something people can find by digging. It is not an object. It belongs to God.

The answer, which comes in verse 23, is that God knows its place, because God made the world by it. And then verse 28 states what he has told humankind: “The fear of the Lord, that is wisdom, and to turn away from evil is understanding.” This is the same line that opens the book of Proverbs (1:7). It is where wisdom begins and also where it ends.

Placed here, in the middle of Job’s suffering, the verse is a challenge and a comfort. Job does not have answers about why he is suffering. But he is being told that wisdom is not the same as having answers. It is fearing God, and refusing evil, in the dark.

STEP 5

Connection

Proverbs 1:7 and 9:10 open and close their wisdom with the same line as verse 28. In the New Testament, Christ is "the wisdom of God" (1 Corinthians 1:24), and in him "are hidden all the treasures of wisdom and knowledge" (Colossians 2:3). James 1:5 invites us: "If any of you lacks wisdom, let him ask God, who gives generously to all."

STEP 6

Application

When you are tempted to say what is easy rather than what is true, remember Job. Your integrity is worth protecting. Ask God for the courage to say true things even when it costs you.

Think about where you go for wisdom. Is it a podcast, a person, a book? Ask whether you are first going to God and his word.

Pray that the "fear of the Lord" becomes your first instinct, and not just a phrase.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God where you need wisdom you cannot find on your own.
- Ask him for a heart that fears him and turns from evil.
- Thank Jesus, in whom all wisdom is found.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 12

"Behold, the fear of the Lord, that is wisdom, and to turn away from evil is understanding."

JOB 28:28

DAY 80 · WEEK 12

Job 29:1-31:40

Job's final defense, his past, his suffering, his oath

Year 1 · Unit 4 · Reading · 90 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Job 29:1-31:40. This is Job's final speech to his friends. It has three parts: a look back at his happier past, a description of his present humiliation, and an oath of innocence. It is long, so read it in three sittings if you need to.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Job's last speech is like a legal brief. He lays out what his life was before, what it is now, and why he believes he is not at fault. It reads like an honest man's last defense in court. He does not insult his friends in this section, and he does not curse God. He sets out his case, and then he asks God to answer. The chapters are long, but they give you the most complete portrait of Job as a person in the whole book.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Job longs for "the months of old, as in the days when God watched over me" (29:2).
2. He remembers his authority in the city gate. The young men stepped back, and the old men rose when he came (29:7-8).
3. He rescued "the poor who cried for help, and the fatherless who had none to help him" (29:12).
4. He says, "I was eyes to the blind and feet to the lame. I was a father to the needy" (29:15-16).
5. Now he is mocked by those whose fathers he would not have put with the dogs of his flock (30:1).

6. “I cry to you for help and you do not answer me; I stand, and you only look at me” (30:20).
7. “You have turned cruel to me; with the might of your hand you persecute me” (30:21).
8. “I made a covenant with my eyes; how then could I gaze at a virgin?” (31:1).
9. He swears that he has not been unjust to his servants, has not withheld food from the poor, has not trusted in gold, and has not rejoiced at an enemy’s ruin (31:13-30).
10. “Oh, that I had one to hear me! (Here is my signature! Let the Almighty answer me!)” (31:35). “The words of Job are ended” (31:40).

STEP 4

Interpretation

There is something moving in chapter 29. The picture of Job as the one who defended the weak is a picture of a man who really loved justice. He did not simply enjoy a position. He used it to rescue the poor. He describes himself as clothed in righteousness and justice like a robe. Nothing here is false. The narrator told you that Job was blameless, and this is what blamelessness looked like in practice.

But look at what he misses most. It is not wealth or status. It is the sense that God was watching over him. “When the Almighty was yet with me” (29:5). The loss of God’s felt presence hurts more than the loss of his children or his health. That is the right order of grief.

Chapter 30 is the opposite picture. Those who once respected him now spit at him. He says that God has become cruel to him. That is a severe statement and the narrator does not correct it here. In fact, Job is describing how things feel. He may not be right about God’s intentions, but he is honest about his experience. The Bible lets him say it.

Chapter 31 is the longest oath in the book. It is a series of “if I have” statements: if I have lusted, if I have been dishonest, if I have been unjust to my servants, if I have ignored the poor, if I have put my trust in money. Each one calls down a curse on himself if it is true. This is how people in the ancient world swore to their innocence. And look at what is covered. Job’s integrity touches his eyes, his business, his household, his generosity, and his heart. This is a man who believes that God’s law applies to every part of life.

At the end Job signs his name. “Here is my signature!” He asks God to answer. And he says, “The words of Job are ended.” He has said everything he has to say. Now he is going to wait for God.

STEP 5

Connection

Job's description of rescuing the poor and clothing himself in righteousness is a picture of the righteous king in Psalm 72:12-14 and Isaiah 11:4-5, and ultimately of Jesus. The "covenant with my eyes" is echoed in Jesus' teaching in Matthew 5:27-30. James 1:27 says that pure religion is "to visit orphans and widows in their affliction."

STEP 6

Application

Look at the list of Job's oath in chapter 31. Choose one area where you want to be more faithful, such as your eyes, your honesty in business, how you treat people who work for you, or how generous you are. Write a one-sentence commitment.

Remember that the deepest loss is losing the sense of God's presence. If you feel that loss, bring it to him honestly.

Ask yourself how you can be "eyes to the blind" to someone this week.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to search your heart and show you what is not right.
- Thank Jesus for being the righteous one who truly cared for the poor.
- Ask him to help you follow Christ in your relationships.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 12

"Behold, the fear of the Lord, that is wisdom, and to turn away from evil is understanding."

JOB 28:28

DAY 81 · WEEK 12

Job 32:1-34:37

Elihu speaks, a better theology, but still insufficient

Year 1 · Unit 4 · Reading · 96 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Job 32:1-34:37. A new character, Elihu, enters the book. Read his speeches carefully and ask yourself two questions: what does he get right, and where does he go wrong?

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Job's friends have stopped speaking, because "he was righteous in his own eyes" (32:1). Then a young man who has been listening, Elihu, speaks up. He has waited because the others were older, but he has grown angry at both sides: at Job for justifying himself rather than God, and at the three friends for failing to answer. Elihu is not mentioned in the prologue or in God's closing words, and scholars have long debated what to make of him. He says some true and fine things, and he also makes errors. Read him critically.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Elihu is the son of Barachel the Buzite, and he is angry with Job "because he justified himself rather than God" (32:2).
2. He says that he waited because the others were older: "I am young in years, and you are aged; therefore I was timid" (32:6).
3. "It is not the old who are wise, nor the aged who understand what is right" (32:9).
4. "The Spirit of God has made me, and the breath of the Almighty gives me life" (33:4).
5. He says, "God speaks in one way, and in two, though man does not perceive it" (33:14), including in dreams and in pain.
6. "If there be for him an angel, a mediator, one of the thousand, to declare to man what is right for him, and he is merciful to him, and says, Deliver him from going down into the

pit, I have found a ransom" (33:23-24).

7. "Far be it from God that he should do wickedness, and from the Almighty that he should do wrong" (34:10).

8. He says, "Job speaks without knowledge; his words are without insight" (34:35), and that Job "adds rebellion to his sin" (34:37).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Elihu is a puzzling figure. He is the only one of Job's four counselors who is not rebuked in the epilogue, but he is also never praised. He speaks for six chapters, and then he vanishes. Most readers have found something to admire and something to be wary of in him.

What he gets right is worth noting. He is right that God speaks to people through many means, including suffering. He is right that God is just. He is right that human beings cannot stand on their own righteousness. His speech about the "mediator" and the "ransom" in 33:23-24 is a high point. It echoes the language that Job himself used in 9:33 and 16:19, and it lifts the idea that there is a way for a sinner to be delivered. Some of what he says points in a direction that will be fulfilled in the gospel.

But he also makes a mistake that is perhaps more subtle than the friends'. He sees suffering mainly as discipline. For Elihu, pain is God's way of warning a person who is heading for the pit. This is sometimes true, but he applies it to Job, whose pain was never meant as a correction. He tells Job that he is adding rebellion to sin, which is a harsh charge for a man who is not guilty of the original sin.

Elihu also speaks with unusual confidence for a young man. "One who is perfect in knowledge is with you" (36:4). He is certain that he has the answer. His speeches are full of "I will" and "I will declare." There is a pride in him that the rest of the book will not let stand.

His speeches serve a purpose in the book. They bring together the best of what the friends said and push it toward the speech of God. They show how close a person can come to the truth and still miss the point. Then God speaks, and everything changes.

STEP 5

Connection

The "mediator" and the "ransom" of 33:23-24 point to Christ, who "gave himself as a ransom for all" (1 Timothy 2:5-6) and to whom "the Spirit" bears witness (John 15:26). Hebrews 12:5-11 develops the idea of suffering as discipline for God's children. 1 Corinthians 8:1 warns that "knowledge puffs up, but love builds up."

STEP 6

Application

Think about how you respond to a person who is a good deal younger or older than you. Do you listen well?

When you give advice, test it on yourself. Would you want someone to say this to you if you were in the same pain?

Notice the “mediator” in verses 23 and 24, and spend a few minutes thanking Jesus for being the one who found the ransom.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God for the different ways he speaks to you.
- Ask him to keep you listening, not only certain.
- Ask him to make you humble with those who suffer.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 12

“Behold, the fear of the Lord, that is wisdom, and to turn away from evil is understanding.”

JOB 28:28

DAY 82 · WEEK 12

Job 35:1-37:24

Elihu's case for God's majesty, the storm approaches

Year 1 · Unit 4 · Reading · 73 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Job 35:1-37:24. Elihu continues with three more speeches. They get steadily more poetic, ending with a long description of a storm. Read chapter 37 as if you are watching a storm roll in, because the next chapter is the answer from the storm.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Elihu's last three speeches are the finest in his section. He starts with a charge that Job is claiming too much, but the speeches build toward a description of God's majesty in nature. By the end, the sky is darkening and the thunder is rolling. There is a sense of something about to happen. In the next chapter, God will speak, and he will speak from the whirlwind.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Elihu asks, "If you have sinned, what do you accomplish against him?" (35:6).
2. He says that people cry out under oppression but do not ask, "Where is God my Maker, who gives songs in the night?" (35:10).
3. "Behold, God is mighty, and does not despise any; he is mighty in strength of understanding" (36:5).
4. "He delivers the afflicted by their affliction and opens their ear by oppression" (36:15).
5. "Behold, God is great, and we know him not; the number of his years is unsearchable" (36:26).
6. He describes rain, thunder, and lightning as the work of God (36:27-33).
7. "God thunders wondrously with his voice; he does great things that we cannot comprehend" (37:5).

8. He tells Job: “Stop and consider the wondrous works of God” (37:14).
9. The final line: “The Almighty, we cannot find him; he is great in power; justice and abundant righteousness he will not violate. Therefore men fear him; he does not regard any who are wise in their own conceit” (37:23-24).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Elihu’s best contribution is his emphasis on God as Maker. In 35:10 he asks a beautiful question: “Where is God my Maker, who gives songs in the night?” It points to something Job and his friends have all but forgotten: God is not only a judge. He is the one who gives songs in the dark. The God who allows the night is also the God who sings in it.

His description in chapter 36 of how God uses affliction deserves attention. “He delivers the afflicted by their affliction.” This is a rich line. God uses suffering to open ears, to teach people, and to bring them to himself. It is a true principle, and many believers can testify that they heard God most clearly in their pain. But Elihu is wrong if he thinks that this is the only reason suffering happens. In Job’s case, the real reason is not that.

The speech ends with weather. The thunderstorm in chapter 37 is a piece of poetry. Elihu says that God sends the snow and the rain, that he controls the clouds, and that no one can comprehend how it all works. “Do you know how God lays his command upon them?” (37:15). It is a series of questions, and it prepares for the greater questions to come. In a way, Elihu has started to do what God will do: use creation to remind a human being how small he is.

The last verse is a good summary. “He does not regard any who are wise in their own conceit.” It is a warning to Job and to Elihu himself. Elihu is also wise in his own conceit, as the book is about to reveal. All the human voices have spoken, and none of them has understood. Now there is silence, and then the storm.

STEP 5

Connection

Psalm 42:8 says, “By day the LORD commands his steadfast love, and at night his song is with me.” Paul and Silas sang hymns in prison at midnight (Acts 16:25). Psalm 29 praises the voice of the LORD in the thunder. Jesus calmed a storm and made the disciples ask, “Who then is this?” (Mark 4:41).

STEP 6

Application

Pay attention to the weather this week. When there is a storm, watch it and pray Psalm 29. Let it remind you that you are small and God is great.

Ask God to give you a song in the night. If you are in a dark season, tell him that you are waiting for the song.

Be wary of any belief that explains everything about suffering. God is great, and we know him not.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Praise God for his greatness, in your own words.
- Thank him for songs in the night.
- Ask him to keep you from being wise in your own eyes.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 12

"Behold, the fear of the Lord, that is wisdom, and to turn away from evil is understanding."

JOB 28:28

DAY 83 · WEEK 12

Job 38:1-39:30

God speaks from the whirlwind, "Where were you?"

Year 1 · Unit 4 · Reading · 71 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Job 38:1-39:30. Slow down. God has not spoken in the book since the prologue. Read his questions aloud and try to answer them honestly. You will find that you cannot.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

After thirty-seven chapters of human speeches, God answers. He comes in a storm, the sort of storm Elihu was describing at the end of his speech. He does not explain Job's suffering. He does not mention the court scene in heaven, or Satan, or the test. He does not defend himself or scold Job. He asks Job a series of questions about the world he has made, and the questions are so large that Job's own question seems to shrink. This is the turning point of the book.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Then the LORD answered Job out of the whirlwind" (38:1).
2. "Who is this that darkens counsel by words without knowledge?" (38:2).
3. "Dress for action like a man; I will question you, and you make it known to me" (38:3).
4. "Where were you when I laid the foundation of the earth? Tell me, if you have understanding" (38:4).
5. "When the morning stars sang together and all the sons of God shouted for joy" (38:7).
6. God shut the sea behind doors and said, "Thus far shall you come, and no farther, and here shall your proud waves be stayed" (38:8-11).
7. "Have you entered into the springs of the sea...Have the gates of death been revealed to you?" (38:16-17).

8. God asks about light, snow, hail, rain, the constellations, and the clouds (38:19-38).
9. “Who provides for the raven its prey, when its young ones cry to God for help?” (38:41).
10. Chapter 39 moves through wild animals: the mountain goat, the wild donkey, the wild ox, the ostrich, the war horse, the hawk, and the eagle.

STEP 4

Interpretation

The first thing to notice is what God does not say. He gives no reason for Job’s suffering. If Job had wanted a theological explanation, he does not receive one. Some readers are disappointed. But think about what has happened. Job has been asking for an audience with God for thirty chapters. Now he has it. And what he receives is not an argument. It is a presence.

The second thing is that God’s questions are pitched at the right size. Job has been treating the world as if it should make sense to him, as if God owed him an account. The questions say: do you know how the world works? Where were you when it began? Do you know how to feed the lion, or when the mountain goats give birth? The point is not to humiliate Job. It is to show him that he is in the middle of a world far larger and wiser than he can see. If he cannot understand the sea, how can he understand the plan of God?

Pay attention to the tenderness behind the questions. The sea is shut in with doors, like a newborn wrapped in swaddling clothes (38:9). The morning stars sing at creation. The raven’s young cry out, and God provides. The wild donkey is given the wilderness as a home, and the ostrich is allowed to be foolish, because he made her that way. This is not a cold, mechanical universe. It is full of joy and wildness and care. It is the work of a God who delights in what he has made.

This is, in a way, the answer to Job’s question. Job wanted to know whether God is just. God’s answer is to show him God’s wisdom and God’s care in a thousand other places, and to invite Job to trust that this wisdom extends to the part of the world he cannot understand: his own suffering.

The answer to suffering is not an explanation. It is the character of the one who rules.

STEP 5

Connection

Psalm 104 is a hymn that follows the same path as God’s speech. Jesus used the birds and flowers to say that the Father cares for his children: “Look at the birds of the air…your heavenly Father feeds them” (Matthew 6:26). Colossians 1:16-17 says that all things were created through the Son, and in him all things hold together.

STEP 6

Application

Go outside and spend ten minutes looking carefully at something God made: an insect, a tree, a cloud. Ask God to teach you something about himself from it.

When you are tempted to demand that God explain himself, return to chapter 38 and answer the questions honestly.

Pray that you would trust God's character even when you cannot see his plan.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Praise God for something he has made that you did not.
- Tell him that you are small and that you trust him because of who he is.
- Ask him to help you delight in what he has made.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 12

"Behold, the fear of the Lord, that is wisdom, and to turn away from evil is understanding."

JOB 28:28

DAY 84 · WEEK 12

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 4 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Job 28:28 several times, and then try to say it without looking. Read the meditation and the week in review, and then choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or discuss with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"Behold, the fear of the Lord, that is wisdom, and to turn away from evil is understanding."

JOB 28:28

REST

Meditation

Job 28:28 is the answer to a question that the whole poem has been asking: where can wisdom be found? After describing all the things human beings can discover, the poem gives a single, simple verse.

"The fear of the Lord, that is wisdom." The word "fear" does not mean terror. It means reverence, awe, and a settled sense that God is God and you are not. It is the posture of a creature before the Creator. To fear the Lord is to take him seriously, to take his words seriously, and to let him be the final authority in your life. It is the starting point of all true knowledge.

"And to turn away from evil is understanding." Here wisdom becomes practical. Understanding is not first about having correct information. It is about the direction of your life. It is a turning. The wise person is not the one who has solved every puzzle but the one who walks away from what is wrong, even when it is costly.

Notice that neither half of the verse claims to explain suffering. This is the wisdom Job needs. He cannot solve the puzzle. But he can fear God and turn from evil, and that is what the narrator said about him in 1:1. The book keeps coming back to that.

For the Christian, this wisdom has a face. Jesus is the wisdom of God. To fear the Lord is to come to Christ, and to turn from evil is to follow him.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you read the last of the debates and the beginning of God's answer. You heard Job describe the oppression of the poor and ask why God does not seem to act, and you heard him praise God's power as only the outskirts of his ways. You read the great poem on wisdom in chapter 28 and Job's vow of integrity. You read Job's long final defense, in which he remembered his better days, described his present pain, and swore that he had not wronged anyone. Then Elihu spoke. He said some wise things and made some mistakes, and he ended with a storm. In the last reading of the week, God answered Job out of the whirlwind with questions about the world he has made. The week taught that wisdom begins with the fear of the Lord, and that God answers not with explanations but with his own greatness.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Chapter 28 says that wisdom cannot be bought or mined. Where have you been looking for wisdom? What would it mean for you to begin with the fear of the Lord this week?

How does Jesus, who is the wisdom of God and who came as a man of suffering, show you what the fear of the Lord and turning from evil look like in practice? Think of one scene from the Gospels where you see this clearly.

God answered Job with questions about creation rather than answers about suffering. What question do you most want God to answer? What would it mean to trust him with it?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Ask God to teach you the fear of the Lord.

Thank him that Jesus is the wisdom of God.

Rest in his greatness this Sabbath.

DAY 85 · WEEK 13

Job 40:1-42:17

Job's response; restoration, the answer is a person

Year 1 · Unit 4 · Reading · 71 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Job 40:1-42:17. This is the end of the book. Job answers God, God speaks again, and then there is an epilogue in prose. Pay special attention to Job's confession in 42:1-6, and to what God says about Job and his friends in 42:7-9.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Yesterday God began to speak. Today he finishes. Job has been silent through the first round of questions, and now God presses him again. He describes two great creatures, Behemoth and Leviathan, which are beyond Job's power to control. Then Job speaks for the last time, and the book moves into its quiet ending. In the prologue you were allowed to see what Job could not. In the epilogue Job sees something that you cannot see unless you have been through what he has: God himself.

STEP 3

Observation

1. God asks, "Shall a faultfinder contend with the Almighty?" (40:2). Job answers, "Behold, I am of small account; what shall I answer you? I lay my hand on my mouth" (40:4).
2. God speaks again and asks, "Will you even put me in the wrong? Will you condemn me that you may be in the right?" (40:8).
3. Behemoth is described as "the first of the works of God" (40:19), strong enough to be calm when the river rages.
4. Leviathan is a creature no one can capture or tame. God says, "Who then is he who can stand before me?" (41:10) and calls him "king over all the sons of pride" (41:34).
5. Job answers, "I know that you can do all things, and that no purpose of yours can be thwarted" (42:2).

6. He admits that he spoke of things beyond him: “Things too wonderful for me, which I did not know” (42:3).
7. “I had heard of you by the hearing of the ear, but now my eye sees you; therefore I despise myself, and repent in dust and ashes” (42:5-6).
8. God tells Eliphaz, “My anger burns against you and against your two friends, for you have not spoken of me what is right, as my servant Job has” (42:7).
9. Job prays for his friends, and the LORD restores his fortunes and gives him twice as much as he had before (42:8-10).
10. Job has seven sons and three daughters again, and he lives 140 years, “old and full of days” (42:13-17).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The final answer of the book is not an argument. It is an encounter. Job says it directly: “I had heard of you by the hearing of the ear, but now my eye sees you.” Before, Job had a faith made of reports and reasoning. He knew the right things about God. Now he has seen him. The suffering did not give Job a reason. It gave him God. That is not a consolation prize. It is the greatest thing that a person can receive.

His repentance needs careful reading. He does not repent of the sins his friends accused him of, because those were false. He repents of speaking about things he did not understand, of treating God as a defendant in his case. “I despise myself” might also be translated “I retract” or “I submit.” He sees how small he is, and how much he had assumed. This is not groveling. It is the right posture of a creature who has seen the Creator.

The surprise in 42:7 is that God vindicates Job over his friends. “You have not spoken of me what is right, as my servant Job has.” How could this be, when Job said such bold and bitter things? The answer seems to be that Job spoke to God, honestly, while the friends spoke about God, dishonestly. They defended him with false claims. Job wrestled with him with true ones. God prefers honest wrestling to false piety.

Notice the next detail. Job prays for the friends who hurt him. The restoration comes after that prayer. The man who longed for a mediator now becomes one. It is a small picture of what Christ will do on a larger scale.

The restoration is real, but it is not the point. The children who died are not replaced, and the new ones are not substitutes for the old. The book does not say that suffering always ends in earthly blessing. But it does say that God is faithful, and that his last word is never the grave.

STEP 5

Connection

James 5:11 says, “You have heard of the steadfastness of Job, and you have seen the purpose of the Lord, how the Lord is compassionate and merciful.” Isaiah 6:5 records a similar response from Isaiah, who sees the Lord and says, “Woe is me!” Paul prays that we might know Christ and the power of his resurrection (Philippians 3:10). Jesus prays for those who persecute him (Luke 23:34).

STEP 6

Application

Think about the difference between knowing about God and knowing him. Which describes you more? Ask God to give you the second.

If someone has wronged you, pray for them this week by name. It may be hard. Do it anyway.

Also, remember that God prefers honest prayer to polite prayer. If you have been holding back what you actually think, tell him.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God you want to see him and not only hear of him.
- Confess any place where you have spoken of what you do not understand.
- Ask him to teach you to pray for those who have hurt you.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 13

“I had heard of you by the hearing of the ear, but now my eye sees you.”

JOB 42:5

DAY 86 · WEEK 13

Ephesians 1:11; Romans 11:33–36; Job 42:1–6

The Decrees of God and Providence

Year 1 · Unit 4 · Doctrine

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Ephesians 1:11, Romans 11:33-36, and Job 42:1-6. Read all three as a single statement about God's purposes: that he works all things according to his will, that his ways are beyond tracing out, and that Job's answer to such a God is to say, "I know that you can do all things."

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

You have just finished the book of Job, and now you pause. This is a doctrinal day, a chance to step back from the story and think about what the Bible teaches about God's rule over the world. Job's book raises a question that every believer eventually faces: if God is in control, why does he allow evil and suffering? You will not find a full answer here. But the Bible teaches clearly that God is sovereign, that he is good, and that he is not the author of sin. Learning to hold these truths together is part of growing up in the faith.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Ephesians 1:11 says that God "works all things according to the counsel of his will." The word "all" is the key.
2. The context is salvation. We "have obtained an inheritance, having been predestined according to the purpose of him who works all things" (Ephesians 1:11).
3. Romans 11:33 cries out, "Oh, the depth of the riches and wisdom and knowledge of God! How unsearchable are his judgments and how inscrutable his ways!"
4. Paul asks, "Who has known the mind of the Lord, or who has been his counselor?" (Romans 11:34). He is quoting Isaiah 40:13, and the next verse echoes Job 41:11.

5. “For from him and through him and to him are all things. To him be glory forever. Amen” (Romans 11:36).
6. In Job 42:2, Job says, “I know that you can do all things, and that no purpose of yours can be thwarted.”
7. In Job 42:3, he admits, “I have uttered what I did not understand, things too wonderful for me, which I did not know.”
8. Job 42:5-6 describes his new sight and his repentance.

DOCTRINAL PAUSE

Doctrinal Focus

The Christian church has long taught that God has a plan for the world and carries it out. Theologians call the plan God’s decree and the carrying out of it providence. The Westminster Confession puts it this way: God, “from all eternity, did by the most wise and holy counsel of his own will, freely and unchangeably ordain whatsoever comes to pass.” It then adds three careful clarifications. God is not the author of sin. No violence is done to the will of creatures. And the freedom and responsibility of secondary causes are not removed but established.

Providence has three parts. First, God preserves his creation. “In him all things hold together” (Colossians 1:17). If God stopped sustaining the world for a moment, it would cease to exist. Second, God concurs with the actions of his creatures. Everything that happens involves real creatures acting, and God’s rule is in and through them. Third, God governs, directing everything toward his purposes.

The book of Job shows all of this at work. Look at chapter 1. The Sabeans raid, fire falls from heaven, the Chaldeans attack, a great wind strikes the house. Each of these is a real event with real agents, and Satan stands behind them, permitted but limited. And yet Job says, “The LORD has taken away.” That is not because Job is confused. It is because he sees that God is above the causes. He is the first cause, and the others are secondary. The same event can be the sin of the Sabeans and the permission of God. Genesis 50:20 says it clearly in Joseph’s words: “You meant evil against me, but God meant it for good.” The cross is the supreme example: “This Jesus, delivered up according to the definite plan and foreknowledge of God, you crucified and killed by the hands of lawless men” (Acts 2:23). God’s plan and human guilt are both real.

How should we hold these together? We should not claim to understand more than the Bible says. Paul does not try to resolve it. He says, “Oh, the depth!” The right response to this doctrine is worship. And it is a comfort. If God rules everything, then nothing in your life is

outside his hand, and nothing is wasted. The Heidelberg Catechism says that all things come to us "not by chance but from his fatherly hand."

There is a caution, too. This doctrine is meant to comfort sufferers, not to be used on them. The friends of Job tried to explain suffering with theology, and God rebuked them. Speak about providence to yourself in your own pain, and to others only with great gentleness.

STEP 4

Interpretation

Job's final answer in 42:2 is a confession of the doctrine we have been discussing. "I know that you can do all things, and that no purpose of yours can be thwarted." It is not the cry of someone who has found a satisfying argument. It is the settled conviction of someone who has been brought low and has seen God.

What makes it remarkable is when Job says it. He says it without having received an explanation. He still does not know about the courtroom scene in heaven. He still does not know why his children died. But he has seen enough of God to know that God's plan will stand. And that is enough.

This is also how Paul speaks in Romans 11. He has just spent three chapters wrestling with how God will bring about the salvation of Israel and the nations. When he reaches the end, he does not offer a final theory. He breaks into praise. The plan is too deep. "To him be glory forever." The doctrine of providence is not meant to end in a diagram. It is meant to end in a doxology.

The lines in Ephesians 1:11 should be read in context. Paul says that God works all things according to the counsel of his will in order to say something about the security of believers. We have an inheritance. We were chosen. God is working, and he will finish what he started. Providence, in the Bible, is mostly a message of hope for the people of God.

STEP 5

Connection

Proverbs 16:9 says, "The heart of man plans his way, but the LORD establishes his steps." Psalm 115:3 says, "Our God is in the heavens; he does all that he pleases." Jesus said that not even a sparrow falls to the ground apart from the Father (Matthew 10:29). Isaiah 46:9-10 declares, "My counsel shall stand, and I will accomplish all my purpose."

STEP 6

Application

First, take a hard thing in your life and ask, "What does it mean that God is sovereign over this?" Write one sentence and one prayer.

Second, notice the difference between the doctrine as a comfort and the doctrine as a weapon. Resolve to use it only for the first.

Third, spend time in worship. Read Romans 11:33-36 aloud as a prayer, and let it end in praise.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God that nothing in your life is outside his hand.
- Tell him about a part of his ways you do not understand, and ask him for trust.
- Give him the glory he is owed.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 13

"I had heard of you by the hearing of the ear, but now my eye sees you."

JOB 42:5

DAY 87 · WEEK 13

Romans 8:18-30; 1 Peter 4:12-19; 2 Corinthians 4:7-18

Suffering and the Christian Life

Year 1 · Unit 4 · Doctrine

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Romans 8:18-30, 1 Peter 4:12-19, and 2 Corinthians 4:7-18. These three passages are the New Testament's most direct teaching on suffering in the Christian life. Read them side by side, and notice what each says about the purpose, the presence, and the end of suffering.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Yesterday you thought about God's sovereignty. Today you think about how Christians are to live under it. The book of Job asked why the righteous suffer, and the answer it gave was God himself. The New Testament adds the missing piece: the answer is the God who has suffered. Paul, Peter, and the others wrote as people who were being beaten, jailed, and persecuted. They are not theorizing. They are speaking from inside the experience.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Paul says, "I consider that the sufferings of this present time are not worth comparing with the glory that is to be revealed to us" (Romans 8:18).
2. The whole creation "waits with eager longing" and "groans together in the pains of childbirth" (8:19-22).
3. We "who have the firstfruits of the Spirit, groan inwardly as we wait eagerly for adoption as sons" (8:23).
4. "The Spirit helps us in our weakness…intercedes for us with groanings too deep for words" (8:26).

5. “For those who love God all things work together for good, for those who are called according to his purpose” (8:28). The good is defined in verse 29: being “conformed to the image of his Son.”

6. Peter says, “Do not be surprised at the fiery trial when it comes upon you to test you, as though something strange were happening to you” (1 Peter 4:12).

7. “But rejoice insofar as you share Christ’s sufferings, that you may also rejoice and be glad when his glory is revealed” (4:13).

8. “Therefore let those who suffer according to God’s will entrust their souls to a faithful Creator while doing good” (4:19).

9. Paul says, “We have this treasure in jars of clay, to show that the surpassing power belongs to God and not to us” (2 Corinthians 4:7).

10. “For this light momentary affliction is preparing for us an eternal weight of glory beyond all comparison” (4:17).

DOCTRINAL PAUSE

Doctrinal Focus

The Christian view of suffering differs from every other view in one important way: it centers on a suffering Savior. Other religions explain suffering as illusion, as karma, or as a mere fact of life. The Bible treats suffering as real, as an enemy, as part of a fallen world, and as something God himself has entered. Jesus “learned obedience through what he suffered” (Hebrews 5:8), and he is “a man of sorrows and acquainted with grief” (Isaiah 53:3). When you suffer, you are not alone.

The New Testament gives several reasons for the suffering of Christians, and it is important to keep them together. First, we suffer because of union with Christ. Paul says we are “fellow heirs with Christ, provided we suffer with him in order that we may also be glorified with him” (Romans 8:17). To belong to Jesus is to share his path, which goes through the cross to glory. Second, suffering refines us. It produces endurance, character, and hope (Romans 5:3-5), and it is the means by which God conforms us to his Son (Romans 8:29). Third, suffering is a witness. Paul carries “the death of Jesus” in his body “so that the life of Jesus may also be manifested in our bodies” (2 Corinthians 4:10). Fourth, suffering is the groaning of a creation that is still waiting for its redemption. We live in the time between the first coming and the second, and all of creation feels it.

We must be careful not to turn any of these reasons into a rule that explains every case. This is exactly what Job’s friends did. Jesus said that a man’s blindness was not caused by his sin or his parents’ (John 9:3). Sometimes we simply do not know why. What we do know is that

God has promised never to leave us, that he is working through everything for our good, and that suffering will end.

That promise is the content of Romans 8:28. It is often quoted as if it said that everything that happens is good. It does not. It says that God works all things together for good, and the good is defined: becoming like Christ and sharing in his glory. That is a much deeper kind of good than comfort. And the verses that follow seal it. Nothing can separate us from the love of God in Christ Jesus (Romans 8:38-39).

The final piece is hope. Paul calls the affliction "light" and "momentary," not because it is trivial but because he is weighing it against "an eternal weight of glory." The scales are not even. The Christian does not deny the pain. He sets it against what is coming.

STEP 4

Interpretation

Each of the three passages tells you something different. In Romans 8, Paul puts our pain in a cosmic frame. It is part of a creation that groans and a Spirit that groans with us. He does not say that the pain is good. He says that it is not the end. The Spirit helps us pray when we have no words, and that is a mercy that Job did not have.

In 1 Peter, the stress is on not being surprised. Peter writes to believers who are facing persecution, and he tells them that this is normal. "Do not be surprised." Many people come to faith expecting an easier life, and they are shaken when trouble comes. Peter says to expect the fiery trial, and to rejoice when you share Christ's sufferings. He also gives a simple instruction for the sufferer: "entrust your soul to a faithful Creator while doing good" (4:19). The phrase "faithful Creator" answers God's speeches in Job. The one who made the world is the one to trust with your soul.

In 2 Corinthians 4, Paul describes himself as a jar of clay. The treasure is the gospel, and the jar is his fragile, breakable body. The weakness is not a flaw in the plan. It is the plan, so that the power will clearly be God's. He says that he is afflicted but not crushed, perplexed but not driven to despair, struck down but not destroyed (4:8-9). Each of the pairs is a picture of someone near the edge who is held.

Together the passages give a full portrait. Suffering is real and costly. It is not a sign that God has left us. It is used by God for good. It is temporary. And it is shared with Christ.

STEP 5

Connection

Job's story points forward to these New Testament passages. Where Job asked for a mediator, Paul says the Spirit intercedes for us. Where Job looked for a redeemer, Peter points to the faithful Creator who is also our Savior. Hebrews 12:1-3 tells us to look to Jesus, who endured the cross. James 1:2-4 and Revelation 21:4 complete the picture: trials now, and no more tears then.

STEP 6

Application

First, if you are suffering now, read Romans 8:18-30 slowly and ask God to help you hear it as a word to you. Identify one phrase that gives you hope.

Second, if you are not suffering, take time to pray for someone who is. Read 1 Peter 4 and ask how you can support a persecuted brother or sister.

Third, learn 2 Corinthians 4:16-17 by heart. It will be a help in your own dark days.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank Jesus that he suffered for you and with you.
- Tell God where you are weak and ask him to show his strength.
- Ask him to fix your eyes on what is unseen.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 13

"I had heard of you by the hearing of the ear, but now my eye sees you."

JOB 42:5

DAY 88 · WEEK 13

Psalm 73

I was nearly slipping; yet I am continually with you

Year 1 · Unit 4 · Psalm · 28 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 73. It is a psalm about a man who nearly lost his faith over the prosperity of the wicked. Read it as a story with a turning point, and find the verse in which everything changes.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 73 is by Asaph, a leader of worship in David's time. It opens the third book of the Psalter, and it is a perfect companion to Job. Both deal with the problem of the prosperity of the wicked and the pain of the righteous. Job came out of the book with a vision of God. Asaph comes out of the psalm with the same thing, and he tells you exactly where it happened.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Truly God is good to Israel, to those who are pure in heart" (v. 1). This is Asaph's starting point.
2. "But as for me, my feet had almost stumbled, my steps had nearly slipped" (v. 2).
3. The reason: "For I was envious of the arrogant when I saw the prosperity of the wicked" (v. 3).
4. The wicked have no pangs until death, and they are not in trouble as others are (vv. 4-5).
5. They speak with malice and set their mouths against the heavens (vv. 8-9). "They say, How can God know? Is there knowledge in the Most High?" (v. 11).
6. Asaph says, "All in vain have I kept my heart clean and washed my hands in innocence" (v. 13).

7. “But when I thought how to understand this, it seemed to me a wearisome task, until I went into the sanctuary of God; then I discerned their end” (vv. 16-17).
8. The wicked are on “slippery places” and are destroyed in a moment (vv. 18-19).
9. “Whom have I in heaven but you? And there is nothing on earth that I desire besides you” (v. 25).
10. “My flesh and my heart may fail, but God is the strength of my heart and my portion forever” (v. 26).
11. “But for me it is good to be near God” (v. 28).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The honest first confession of the psalm is worth noticing. Asaph says that he almost fell. He nearly gave up. The reason was not an intellectual doubt but an emotional one: envy. He looked at people who ignored God and seemed to be doing fine, and he felt that his own faithfulness had been a waste. Most believers have felt this.

He describes the wicked in detail. They are fat, free from pain, proud, and violent. They scoff at God. Their prosperity seems to say that there is no judgment. It is a convincing picture, and Asaph does not pretend that it is not.

Then comes verse 16. He tried to think his way through it, and it was “wearisome.” He could not reason it out. The turning point is in verse 17: “until I went into the sanctuary of God.” Something happened in God’s presence that thinking alone could not do. He saw things from the perspective of eternity. “Then I discerned their end.” The picture that looked so solid was a house on slippery ground.

The sanctuary is the place where God is worshiped, and it is where the truth about the world comes back into view. If your perspective is bent by what you see, go to where God is. This is why public worship matters.

What follows is one of the great confessions in the Psalter. “Whom have I in heaven but you?” Asaph moves from envy to desire. He no longer wants what the wicked have. He wants God. He even says that his flesh and heart may fail, and God will still be “the strength of my heart and my portion forever.” The word “portion” recalls the way the tribes were given land. His inheritance is God himself. He ends with the line that carries the whole psalm: “for me it is good to be near God.”

This is exactly where Job ended. The answer to the problem of suffering and unfairness is not a theory. It is God.

STEP 5

Connection

Psalm 37 deals with the same theme, and so does Jeremiah 12:1. Jesus said, “What does it profit a man to gain the whole world and forfeit his soul?” (Mark 8:36). Paul says that his gain is Christ (Philippians 3:7-8). The idea of God as our portion appears in Lamentations 3:24: “The LORD is my portion, says my soul, therefore I will hope in him.”

STEP 6

Application

If you are envious of someone’s success, take your envy to God in worship. Go to a church service or to a quiet place and sit in his presence. Ask him to show you the end.

Pray verses 25 and 26 as your own. Say them aloud, and then ask yourself if they are honestly true. If not, ask God to make them true.

Pay attention this week to what you desire most. Ask God to teach you to want him more than anything else.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Confess any envy, and tell God where your feet have nearly slipped.
- Ask him to bring you into his presence and show you the truth.
- Tell him what it means that he is your portion.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 13

“I had heard of you by the hearing of the ear, but now my eye sees you.”

JOB 42:5

DAY 89 · WEEK 13

Psalm 88

O LORD, God of my salvation, the darkest lament

Year 1 · Unit 4 · Psalm · 18 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 88. It is the darkest psalm in the Psalter, and it is meant to be. Read it slowly and do not hurry to a happy ending. There is not one. Notice how it begins, and notice what the psalmist keeps doing.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 88 is attributed to Heman the Ezrahite, a wise man mentioned in 1 Kings 4:31. It is the only lament in the Psalter that ends with no note of hope. Other laments move from complaint to trust. This one begins in darkness and ends in darkness. Why would the Bible include a prayer like this? The answer is that God knows some of his people will walk through seasons that feel exactly like it, and he wants them to know that they are allowed to pray in that darkness. Compare it to Job in his worst chapters.

STEP 3

Observation

1. The first line is a statement of faith: “O LORD, God of my salvation” (v. 1).
2. He cries “day and night” before God and asks that his prayer would come before him (vv. 1-2).
3. “My soul is full of troubles, and my life draws near to Sheol” (v. 3). He feels like one who is already dead (vv. 4-5).
4. “You have put me in the depths of the pit, in the regions dark and deep” (v. 6).
5. “Your wrath lies heavy upon me, and you overwhelm me with all your waves” (v. 7).
6. “You have caused my companions to shun me; you have made me a horror to them” (v. 8).

7. “Every day I call upon you, O LORD; I spread out my hands to you” (v. 9).
8. He asks, “Do you work wonders for the dead? Do the departed rise up to praise you?” (v. 10).
9. “But I, O LORD, cry to you; in the morning my prayer comes before you” (v. 13).
10. “O LORD, why do you cast my soul away? Why do you hide your face from me?” (v. 14).
11. The last line is “my companions have become darkness” (v. 18).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Start with what the psalm does not have. There is no turn. No “But you.” No vow to praise. No assurance that God has heard. The psalmist ends with the word “darkness.” If you came to this psalm hoping to be cheered up, you will be disappointed.

But look at what the psalm does have. It begins with “O LORD, God of my salvation.” This is the only line in the psalm that points to light, and it comes first. Whatever else is true, the psalmist is still talking to the God who saves. He does not understand how God can be his salvation and feel like his enemy. But he refuses to stop addressing him. And he says, “Every day I call upon you.” He keeps praying. He spreads out his hands. In verse 13, he says that his prayer will come before God “in the morning.” The darkness has not stopped him from praying.

That is the quiet wonder of the psalm. Faith in this psalm is not a feeling of hope. It is the act of continuing to pray when there is no feeling. It is clinging to the one who seems to be against you. The psalm itself is a prayer, and so it is itself the evidence that the psalmist has not let go.

It is also important to see that God’s word includes this prayer. The Bible does not demand that all faith be cheerful. It gives a place for the person who has no light, and it says, in effect, “Here are words you can use.” If you ever find yourself unable to say anything hopeful, this psalm says that you can still say, “LORD, God of my salvation,” and keep praying.

Finally, the psalm points to Christ. The one who, more than any other, was shunned by companions and overwhelmed by waves of wrath is Jesus. On the cross he took the wrath that lay heavy on us, and he went into the darkness so that we could come out of it. Psalm 88 is, in a deeper sense, his prayer.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus' experience of being deserted by his friends (Mark 14:50) and of bearing the wrath of God is a fulfillment of this psalm. Lamentations 3:1-18 is another prayer that ends in the dark, until verse 19 and following. Hebrews 5:7 describes Jesus offering up prayers with loud cries and tears. Romans 8:26 says the Spirit prays for us when we cannot.

STEP 6

Application

If you are in a dark season, pray this psalm. You do not need to add a happy ending. Say "LORD, God of my salvation," and then say whatever is true.

If you know someone who is in a dark season, resist the urge to hand them a quick answer. Sit with them. Sometimes the best thing you can do is to pray Psalm 88 with them.

Thank Jesus for going into the darkness for you, and for the promise that one day there will be no more.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Tell God what the dark feels like, without tidying it up.
- Thank Jesus for going into the dark for you.
- Hold in prayer someone you love who is in the dark today.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 13

"I had heard of you by the hearing of the ear, but now my eye sees you."

JOB 42:5

DAY 90 · WEEK 13

Psalm 17

Hear a just cause, O LORD, David's appeal to integrity

Year 1 · Unit 4 · Psalm · 15 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 17. This is a prayer of David, a man who is under attack and is asking God for vindication. Read it with Job in mind, and notice both the confidence of its opening and the hope of its closing line.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 17 is attributed to David, and its tone is similar to some of Job's. Both men appeal to God as a judge, both claim to have been faithful, and both are surrounded by enemies. David's confidence in his integrity may sound proud at first reading. But look at what he is doing: he is not claiming perfection. He is claiming to be on the right side in a particular dispute, and he is bringing the case to God, the only judge who can settle it. The psalm ends with one of the loveliest hopes in the Psalter.

STEP 3

Observation

1. The psalm begins, "Hear a just cause, O LORD; attend to my cry! Give ear to my prayer from lips free of deceit!" (v. 1).
2. "From your presence let my vindication come! Let your eyes behold the right!" (v. 2).
3. "You have tried my heart, you have visited me by night, you have tested me, and you will find nothing; I have purposed that my mouth will not transgress" (v. 3).
4. "Wondrously show your steadfast love, O Savior of those who seek refuge from their adversaries" (v. 7).
5. "Keep me as the apple of your eye; hide me in the shadow of your wings" (v. 8).
6. The enemies surround him. They are like a lion eager to tear (vv. 9-12).

7. “Arise, O LORD! Confront him, subdue him!” (v. 13).
8. The wicked have their reward in this life, with plenty of children and wealth (v. 14).
9. “As for me, I shall behold your face in righteousness; when I awake, I shall be satisfied with beholding your likeness” (v. 15).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm begins with the language of a courtroom. David is making a case. “Hear a just cause.” He is not demanding mercy because he is weak. He is claiming that his cause is right. And he does so by saying that God has already examined him and found nothing wrong. “You have tried my heart…and you will find nothing.” This is not a statement that David is sinless. It is a statement that he has not done what his enemies accuse him of. It is also a statement that God is the final judge, and that David is willing to have his heart examined by him.

Job made the same appeal. “Oh, that I had one to hear me! Let the Almighty answer me!” The difference is that David is more confident that God will respond. He also adds a second image, one of intimacy and protection. “Keep me as the apple of your eye; hide me in the shadow of your wings.” The apple of the eye is the pupil, the most sensitive and protected part of the body. The shadow of the wings is a picture of a mother bird covering her young. David asks for two things at once: to be vindicated like a defendant in court, and to be held like a child. The psalm is a mixture of legal and tender language, and so is the gospel.

Verse 14 is worth noticing. The wicked are filled with the things of this life: wealth, children, a full belly. David does not envy them. He simply notes that this is all they have. Their “portion is in this life.” It echoes Psalm 73 and the end of Job.

And then the ending, which is the heart of the psalm. “As for me, I shall behold your face in righteousness.” David does not say that he wants to be wealthy or safe. He wants to see God’s face. He says that when he wakes, probably a reference to waking from death or from the long night of trouble, he will be “satisfied with beholding your likeness.” This is the same longing Job had in 19:26. “In my flesh I shall see God.” It is the hope that the Old Testament believers held onto: to see God.

STEP 5

Connection

Jesus speaks of the pure in heart who “shall see God” (Matthew 5:8). Paul says, “Now we see in a mirror dimly, but then face to face” (1 Corinthians 13:12). John writes, “We know that when he appears we shall be like him, because we shall see him as he is” (1 John 3:2). Revelation 22:4 says, “They will see his face.” Jesus compared himself to a hen who gathers her chicks under her wings (Matthew 23:37).

STEP 6

Application

Ask God to examine your heart, as David does. Say “You have tried my heart” and then listen. Confess whatever comes to mind, and receive the forgiveness that is yours in Christ.

Ask yourself if you want to see God’s face more than anything else. If not, ask him to put that desire in you.

Take comfort in the picture of the apple of his eye. Say aloud, “I am the apple of his eye.” If that is hard to believe, bring that to him too.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to search your heart and show you what is wrong.
- Ask him to hide you in the shadow of his wings.
- Tell him you long to be satisfied in him.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 13

“I had heard of you by the hearing of the ear, but now my eye sees you.”

JOB 42:5

DAY 91 · WEEK 13

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 1 · Unit 4 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Job 42:5 slowly, several times, then say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or discuss.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"I had heard of you by the hearing of the ear, but now my eye sees you."

JOB 42:5

REST

Meditation

Job 42:5 is the center of the book of Job. After forty-one chapters of arguing, questioning, suffering, and listening, Job says something quiet.

"I had heard of you by the hearing of the ear." This is how most of us begin. We hear about God from our parents, a preacher, a book, or a friend. We know the facts. We can say the creeds. That is a good beginning, and it is a real knowledge, but it is secondhand. It is a report.

"But now my eye sees you." Something has changed. Job has encountered God. He is no longer relying on what others have said. He has seen the Lord in the whirlwind, heard his voice, and been met by his presence. The word "now" tells you that this is the result of everything that has come before. Suffering, with all its pain, led him here.

This is one of the most hopeful statements in the Bible. It means that the purpose of suffering, in the deepest sense, is not to teach us a lesson or to punish us. It is to bring us to the place where we see God. This does not mean that the suffering is good in itself. It is not. But God can use it to give you a clearer sight of himself than you had before.

For the Christian, the verse is even richer. In Jesus, "we have seen his glory" (John 1:14). He is the one in whom the invisible God has become visible. To see Jesus is to see the Father (John 14:9). Every Christian's journey is from hearing to seeing, and it is finished when we see him face to face.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you finished the book of Job. You read God's answer from the whirlwind and the questions about creation that silenced Job. You read the last chapters, in which God vindicated Job over his friends, Job prayed for them, and the LORD restored his fortunes. You paused for two doctrinal days: on the decrees of God and providence, and on suffering and the Christian life. You saw that God rules over every event, that he is not the author of sin, and that Christians suffer in union with a suffering Savior. You prayed three psalms alongside Job. Psalm 73 showed you the sanctuary as the place where perspective returns. Psalm 88 gave you a prayer for the dark that has no easy ending. Psalm 17 gave you the hope of seeing God's face. The week taught that the answer to suffering is the presence of God.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Job went from hearing about God to seeing him. Where are you on that path? What would it look like for your knowledge of God to become less secondhand?

How does Jesus, the visible image of the invisible God, fulfill what Job longed for? Think about a moment in the Gospels where Jesus shows you what God is like, and what it means that you can see him there.

Of the three psalms you read this week, which one was closest to where you are right now? Write a prayer in your own words that begins with that psalm.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Tell God you want to see him and not only hear of him.

Thank him for Jesus, in whom you see his glory.

Ask him to use suffering to draw you nearer.

DAY 92 · WEEK 14

Psalm 26

Vindicate me, O LORD, for I have walked in my integrity

Year 1 · Unit 4 · Psalm · 12 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 26. It is another prayer of David about integrity. Read it carefully, and watch for the way the confident opening gives way to a request for mercy in the final verses.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

This is the last psalm of the unit, and it fits the theme well. Job swore an oath of integrity in Job 31, and David does something similar here. He asks God to examine him and declares that he has walked faithfully. The question is how a sinful man can say such things. The answer is in the last two verses, where David asks to be redeemed. His integrity is real, but it is not his ground of acceptance. His ground is God's steadfast love.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Vindicate me, O LORD, for I have walked in my integrity, and I have trusted in the LORD without wavering" (v. 1).
2. "Prove me, O LORD, and try me; test my heart and my mind" (v. 2).
3. "For your steadfast love is before my eyes, and I walk in your faithfulness" (v. 3).
4. He does not sit with the worthless or go in with hypocrites (vv. 4-5).
5. "I wash my hands in innocence and go around your altar, O LORD" (v. 6).
6. "O LORD, I love the habitation of your house and the place where your glory dwells" (v. 8).
7. "Do not sweep my soul away with sinners, nor my life with bloodthirsty men" (v. 9).
8. "But as for me, I shall walk in my integrity; redeem me, and be gracious to me" (v. 11).

9 “My foot stands on level ground; in the great assembly I will bless the LORD” (v. 12).

STEP 4

Interpretation

This is a psalm that raises a question for many new believers: how can anyone say “I have walked in my integrity”? It sounds like boasting. But there are three things to see.

First, the integrity is about direction, not perfection. David says that he has trusted in the LORD “without wavering.” He is not claiming to have never sinned. He is saying that his life has been oriented toward God, and that he has not given his loyalty to anyone else. The Hebrew word for integrity means wholeness or completeness. It describes a life that is not divided.

Second, the integrity is rooted in God’s love. Look at verse 3: “Your steadfast love is before my eyes.” The reason he walks faithfully is that he has been looking at God’s love. His obedience is a response to grace, not an attempt to earn it.

Third, and most important, the psalm ends with a request for mercy. “Redeem me, and be gracious to me.” David has been describing his faithfulness for ten verses, and then he asks for redemption and grace. These are the words of someone who knows he needs saving. He does not say, “Redeem me because I deserve it.” He says, “Redeem me, and be gracious.” He is trusting in God, not in his own record. The same is true in Job, who is declared righteous by God and yet longs for a Redeemer.

The picture at the end is of firm ground. “My foot stands on level ground.” In a psalm full of danger and temptation, the final image is of a safe place to stand, and a congregation gathered to praise.

This is what the unit has been moving toward. In the face of suffering and injustice, the faithful person says: I will walk in my integrity, and I will trust in God’s grace.

STEP 5

Connection

Paul says that his own righteousness is “a righteousness not my own, but that which comes through faith in Christ” (Philippians 3:9). In Psalm 130:3-4 the psalmist says, “If you, O LORD, should mark iniquities, O Lord, who could stand? But with you there is forgiveness.” Hebrews 10:22 invites us to draw near “with a true heart in full assurance of faith.”

STEP 6

Application

Pray this psalm as a final prayer for the unit. Ask God to test your heart and mind. Then, like David, say, “Redeem me, and be gracious to me.”

Think about where you have been divided. What would it mean for your life to be more whole this week?

Plan to be in the “great assembly” on Sunday, and sing with the congregation.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to test your heart and mind.
- Admit that you cannot walk in integrity on your own, and ask for his help.
- Bless him for setting your foot on level ground.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 14

“God said to Moses, I AM WHO I AM. And he said, Say this to the people of Israel: I AM has sent me to you.”

EXODUS 3:14

DAY 93 · WEEK 14

Review and Reflection

Unit 4 review, Job, Suffering & Sovereignty

Year 1 · Unit 4 · Review

MEMORY

Unit Verse

> "For I know that my Redeemer lives, and at the last he will stand upon the earth."
>
> JOB 19:25

REST

Meditation

Job 19:25 is the unit's anchor verse, and it deserves a final look. Read it aloud once more before you go on.

"For I know." This is the language of certainty. Job has been saying "I do not understand" for eighteen chapters. Now he says "I know." The things he does not know are many. What he knows is one thing, and it is enough.

"That my Redeemer lives." The word for "Redeemer" is the family rescuer, the one who steps in when a relative is in trouble. Job does not say that he hopes for one or that he wishes for one. He says that he has one, and that this person is alive. In the middle of death and loss, he points to life.

"And at the last he will stand upon the earth." There will be a final day. The Redeemer will take his place on the earth, as a judge or an advocate in a courtroom. The one who seems to be missing will come. The wrongs will be set right.

Job could not have known how fully this would be fulfilled. In Jesus, the Redeemer has come, lived, died, and risen. He lives, and he will stand upon the earth again. Every Christian can say this verse with more confidence than Job, because we have seen the empty tomb. Keep the verse close. It will carry you through the hardest days.

LOOK BACK

Unit Recap

In Unit 4 you have read the book of Job and a series of psalms that go with it. The unit began with a scene that Job himself never saw: the heavenly court, where Satan accused Job of serving God only for the benefits. God allowed Job to be tested, within limits, and Job lost his children, his wealth, and his health. Even so, he worshiped. You prayed Psalms 10 and 13, which gave you words for “Where are you?” and “How long?”

Then the friends came. Eliphaz, Bildad, and Zophar each spoke three times, and they all said the same thing in different ways: Job must have sinned. They defended God with false claims, and they turned a general truth about wisdom and consequences into a rule that crushed a suffering man. Job answered them with grief and anger and honesty. Through his speeches, a longing grew: for an arbiter, for a witness in heaven, and for a Redeemer who lives. In chapter 19 he said the words that anchor this unit.

You read Psalm 22, the great psalm of the forsaken and the vindicated, and saw how Jesus prayed it on the cross. In the later chapters, Job insisted on his integrity, praised God’s power as only the outskirts of his ways, and heard the poem on wisdom that ends with the fear of the Lord. Elihu spoke last among the humans, and he said some wise things and some mistaken ones.

Then God answered from the whirlwind. He did not explain, but asked questions about the world he had made. Job saw him, repented of his presumption, and prayed for his friends. God vindicated Job and restored him. In two doctrinal pauses, you studied God’s providence and the Christian’s suffering. In Psalms 73, 88, 17, and 26, you found a sanctuary where the truth comes back into focus, a prayer for the darkest night, the hope of seeing God’s face, and a plea for redemption.

The unit taught that suffering is not a verdict, that God is sovereign and good, and that the answer to suffering is not an explanation but a Person.

REFLECT

Review Questions

What does the prologue of Job reveal about the nature of suffering and Satan’s role?

Look back at chapters 1 and 2. Satan can act only with God’s permission, and every time the permission has a limit. Job’s suffering was not punishment, and he never learned the reason. What does this teach you about how to think about suffering in your own life? How does it help you to know that Satan is on a leash?

Where do Job's friends go wrong in their theology of suffering?

The friends held a general truth, that sin has consequences, and turned it into a rule that explained everything. Recall how they treated Job, and how God responded in 42:7. What lessons about comforting people and handling Scripture do you take from their mistakes? Is there a place where you are tempted to do what they did?

How does God's answer from the whirlwind address Job's questions?

God did not give Job an explanation. He asked questions about creation, and showed Job his own wisdom and care. Job's response was, "Now my eye sees you." Why was that enough? Write a few sentences about what it means that the answer to suffering is God himself.

How does Job's story point forward to Christ, the truly righteous one who suffered?

Think about Job's longing for a mediator, a witness, and a Redeemer, and about Psalm 22. Jesus is the righteous one who suffered unjustly, the mediator who stands between God and us, and the Redeemer who lives. Write a short prayer of thanks to him for each of these roles.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that suffering is never a sign he has left you.

Ask him to help you trust him when you do not understand.

Ask him to prepare you for what comes next.